

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

WEDNESDAY 12 AUGUST 2026

 A crude oil tanker at sea

THE SQUEEZE · A SHUT STRAIT, A GOLD RECORD, AND A NUMBER THAT PRINTS TONIGHT

THE WORLD

A Hormuz "deal" that bars two navies and charges rent — and the oil price does the talking

THE LONG READ

The man the AI boom laid off built Korea a map for the broke — 1.3 million used it

THE RABBIT HOLE

The screen-free craft where you don't own the pot until it survives two fires

Twelve Desks · Source: Wikimedia Commons — a crude oil tanker, standing in for the One World chokepoint the lead turns on (p3). Representative image.

THIS ISSUE

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FROM THE DESK

"Beware of little expenses; a small leak will sink a great ship."

— Benjamin Franklin, *Poor Richard's Almanack*¹

The squeeze runs through the book: a chokepoint learning to charge rent as oil drags a CPI toward the light (p3, p14); households the Rally calls "stretched" (p5); an eleven-year-old at the pressure point of the research (p12); a Korean generation that turned going-without into a game with 1.3 million players (p21). Franklin's leak is small, steady, and it sinks the ship.

THE STRIP — AT TUESDAY'S CLOSE

LEVEL	11 AUG
VWRA (All-World)	~\$194.6
US 10-Year	~4.70%
DXY	~99.7
USD/SGD	~1.280
USD/JPY	~159.3
Brent	~\$88
Gold (XAU)	>\$4,400
Bitcoin	~\$64.3k
STI	~5,700

Latest at Tuesday's US session; arrows show direction on the week. An oil-led inflation scare bid up gold and yields together — CPI prints tonight SGT (p14).²

THE WEEK AHEAD — WHAT WE ARE WAITING TO BE ABLE TO GRADE

- 🕒 **TONIGHT, WED 12 AUG — US July CPI** (20:30 SGT). The print the book turns on: a hot number on an oil scare hardens the higher-for-longer bid; a soft one unwinds the yield spike and wobbles a record gold (p14).³
- 🕒 **THU 13 AUG — BIGBANG general sale**, 10am — the one act-now item, a fast Kallang sell-out (p19). Then **17 Aug**:

Qwen3.8's promised open weights, still undelivered — grade them (p7).⁴

- 🕒 **THE FORTNIGHT — 23 Aug** the Rally needs a number (p5); **~26 Aug** the first X6 lab review (p9); **~28 Aug** the Bridgers audience verdict; **1 Sep** the New Upper Changi tender (p6).⁵

SOURCES 1 Benjamin Franklin, *Poor Richard's Almanack* (attrib.). 2 Market strip, Tue 11 Aug 2026 US session: VWRA ~\$194.6, US 10Y ~4.70% (one-month high), DXY ~99.7, USD/SGD ~1.280, USD/JPY ~159.3, Brent ~\$88, gold >\$4,400, BTC ~\$64.3k; STI ~5,700 held on the last clear print — TradingEconomics; stockanalysis.com; Yahoo Finance; Fortune; SGX. Several levels single-sourced. Not investment advice. 3 US July CPI due 12 Aug, 20:30 SGT (BLS) — after this edition; awaiting (p14). 4 BIGBANG general sale 13 Aug 10am; Qwen3.8 open weights promised the week of 10 Aug, undelivered — grade 17 Aug — Ticketmaster SG; byteiota. 5 National Day Rally 23 Aug; X6 first lab reviews ~late Aug; Bridgers audience score ~28 Aug; New Upper Changi GLS closes 1 Sep — PMO; URA; Metacritic. Graded when the check-by passes.

THE WORLD · THE CHOKEPOINT

The Deal Is "Very Close." The Toll Booth Is Already Built.

Tehran and Muscat now say a Hormuz corridor is nearly agreed. Read the terms Iran is publishing and it is not a reopening at all: a lane that bars American and Israeli-linked ships, fines violators a fifth of their cargo, and stays shut until Washington pays for an alleged June breach. Six months into the closure, the market has stopped waiting for the strait and started paying to go around it — and Brent, near US\$88, is the number doing the talking.

A reopening you cannot sail is a toll booth with a press release. Through this week Iranian and Omani officials have called a Hormuz agreement "very close" — and the terms Tehran's state media are publishing describe the opposite of open water: a pact that would bar all US- and Israeli-linked vessels, fine violators up to a fifth of their cargo's value, and run ships on a temporary route only until a replacement is negotiated for the pre-war Traffic Separation Scheme.¹ Iran's foreign minister says reopening stays "subject to other conditions," compensation from the United States among them; Oman calls the talks "constructive" but warns that continuing Iranian attacks on shipping threaten the whole thing.¹ As of filing no routine commercial transit has resumed the lane — last issue's "still no ship" now settled fact.²

So the trade has rerouted around the politics. Traffic runs on the Jask-Khasab and Musandam workaround

corridors, where shipping-risk desks count the operator roster up roughly threefold since February — owners pricing a *managed* closure, not a reopening.³ The oil market reads it the same way: Brent has firmed toward US\$88, a reported Houthi strike on a Saudi Aramco refinery adding a second supply scare on top of the strait.² War-risk premiums remain high; nobody books a Gulf transit on a communiqué. A corridor priced by one side, barred to two navies, and conditioned on a payment the other calls extortion is not a thaw — it is a chokepoint learning to charge rent.³

~US\$88

BRENT CRUDE, FIRM ON THE WEEK — THE STRAIT STILL SHUT, A REFINERY REPORTEDLY HIT, AND THE OIL PRICE, NOT THE DIPLOMACY, TELLING YOU WHICH WAY THE RISK IS RUNNING (SEE THE MACRO DESK, P14).²

CLOSURE, MONTH 6

A TOLL, NOT A REOPENING

OIL IS THE TELL

TEHRAN — VIA STATE MEDIA

"OUR WATER, OUR TERMS"

The Iranian framing casts the deal as sovereignty, not a climbdown: a pact that "prohibits US and Israeli vessels," fines violators up to 20% of cargo value, and holds reopening hostage to American compensation for an alleged June breach. It is leverage published as law — a lane Tehran can meter, extend or close at will.¹

MUSCAT — THE MEDIATOR

"CONSTRUCTIVE, BUT FRAGILE"

Oman, the broker, calls the talks "constructive" while warning that continuing Iranian attacks on vessels "threaten progress" — the careful language of a mediator who wants the flows restored and cannot control the party doing the shooting. The reopening it is lobbying for is the one still being used as a bargaining table.¹

THE SCEPTIC — "VERY CLOSE" IS A POSTURE, NOT A TRANSIT DATE

Hold the announcement to the water. "Very close" has recurred since April, when a brief early-spring ceasefire moved "first ships" headlines before traffic re-restricted within days — each deal slipping on the same Iranian conditionality now on display.¹ The agreement is real only when three things happen together: the joint text is published, a Western-allied hull runs the lane unmolested, and that first transit is charged or waved through. None had at filing — and the grey-market shippers earning a premium on the workaround have every reason to keep the front door shut.³

SOURCES 1 Iran-Oman Hormuz corridor "very close" (this week) — Iranian state media detail a pact prohibiting US- and Israeli-linked vessels, fining violators up to ~20% of cargo value, ships on a temporary route pending a replacement Traffic Separation Scheme; Iran's foreign minister says reopening remains "subject to other conditions," incl. US compensation; Oman calls talks "constructive" but warns Iranian attacks "threaten progress" — CNN live (8 Aug 2026); NPR (7 Aug 2026) (Iranian-sourced terms; US disputes elements — HELD). 2 Strait largely shut since late Feb 2026; no routine commercial transit at filing; Brent ~US\$88; a reported Houthi strike on a Saudi Aramco refinery (~9 Aug) added a second supply scare — TradingEconomics; Fortune; CNN (Aramco detail single-region-sourced — flagged). 3 Workaround corridors (Jask-Khasab / Musandam) — operator roster up ~3x since Feb; war-risk premiums elevated; owners pricing a managed closure — Lloyd's List Intelligence (5 Aug 2026). Framings attributed; disputed claims flagged.

THE WORLD · THE GROUND MOVES

A Mountain Town Buried in Colombia, a Peace Plan Its Own Sponsor Can't Sign

A magnitude-7.4 earthquake — Colombia's strongest this century — flattened a corner of the western cordillera on Monday, killing well over a hundred and handing a president days into the job his first disaster. In Gaza, the ten-month ceasefire still holds, but Benjamin Netanyahu has rejected the very fifteen-point plan Washington drew up to end the war. One story is the earth moving; the other is a settlement that will not.

At 7:34 on Monday morning the western cordillera lurched, and a region woke into rubble. A magnitude-7.4 earthquake — the strongest to hit Colombia this century — struck about three miles from San José del Palmar in Chocó, collapsing at least eighty-six buildings, suspending seven airports and killing, by the ranges wires could agree on, somewhere between roughly 130 and 170 people, with more than 570 injured and the toll still climbing as crews reached the mountain villages.¹ The government declared a national disaster. Abelardo De La Espriella, the hard-right president sworn in only days earlier, said he had "directly assumed leadership of the emergency response" — a maiden test no transition rehearses. Handle the count as provisional: it moved from ~130 to "more than 160" across outlets inside a day, and mountain tolls tend to rise before they settle.¹

Gaza's fault line is political, and it runs through Washington's own plan. On Sunday 10 August Netanyahu rejected President Trump's revised fifteen-point roadmap, saying Israel will not withdraw from the roughly 60% of Gaza it holds until

Hamas is fully disarmed — while Hamas the same day reaffirmed its commitment to the framework and demanded guarantees on ceasefire, withdrawal and aid.² Al Jazeera reads the move as a hedge — "Netanyahu hedges on Gaza roadmap," deliberate stalling rather than outright refusal; the US wires read a blunter US-Israel rift.² The Philadelphia Inquirer calls it "a balancing act he has mastered," a coalition-management play that keeps the far right onside without formally killing Trump's initiative. The guns are largely quiet; the paper to end them is not signed.²

STILL ON THE WIRE

Colombia, M7.4 — the century's strongest quake near San José del Palmar; ~130–170 dead, 570+ hurt, 86+ buildings down, a national disaster declared.¹

Ukraine's lethal week — a 5 Aug barrage of ~29 missiles and 115 drones killed ~17 in the Kyiv region; a Ukrainian drone strike reportedly killed 13+ inside Russia ~10 Aug; Trump's 8 Aug deadline passed with no new sanctions.³

The oil bridge — Houthis reportedly struck a Saudi Aramco refinery, adding a supply scare to the Hormuz squeeze (p14).³

THE READ — THREE THEATRES, ONE WEEK

Set them side by side and the week's connective tissue is fragility — of ground, of ceasefires, of supply. A cordillera gives way; a truce holds only because neither side yet wants the alternative; the oil price twitches on a refinery fire and a shut strait. For a Singapore reader the practical thread runs to the Macro Desk: Middle East supply scares are pushing Brent toward US\$88 and lifting the inflation risk the book is waiting on (p14). The rest is human, and mostly beyond a portfolio.²

THE SCEPTIC — MIND THE ROUND NUMBERS

Handle all of it with care. A disaster toll in the first forty-eight hours is a moving figure, and Colombia's ran across a wide range before crews had even reached the worst-hit villages — cite the range, not a point.¹ A rejected peace plan is a bargaining posture as often as a final word, and Israel's read of events on the ground is one government's account, not an independent one.² The Aramco-strike detail is, at filing, single-region-sourced. Attribute the claims, wait for the delivery, and treat every number here as provisional until a second outlet or a verified step confirms it.³

SOURCES 1 Colombia earthquake — M7.4 at 07:34 local, Mon 10 Aug 2026, epicentre ~3 mi from San José del Palmar (Chocó); ~130–170 killed (toll ranged), 570+ injured, 86+ buildings collapsed, seven airports suspended; national disaster declared; President Abelardo De La Espriella (sworn in days earlier) "directly assumed leadership" — CNN; Al Jazeera; NBC News; Washington Post, 10 Aug 2026 (range used). 2 Gaza — Netanyahu rejected Trump's revised 15-point plan (10 Aug), no withdrawal from ~60% held until Hamas fully disarmed; Hamas reaffirmed the roadmap — NBC News; Al Jazeera ("Netanyahu hedges...," 11 Aug); Philadelphia Inquirer (11 Aug 2026). Israeli reads flagged; evenhanded. 3 Ukraine — 5 Aug barrage ~29 missiles + 115 drones killed ~17 (Kyiv region); ~10 Aug Ukrainian drone strike reportedly killed 13+ inside Russia; Trump's 8 Aug deadline passed without new sanctions — Al Jazeera; NPR; Washington Post. Houthi strike on a Saudi Aramco refinery (~9 Aug) — CNN; Democracy Now (single-region-sourced — flagged). Casualty figures unreconciled — HELD.

SINGAPORE • BEFORE THE RALLY

A Widening Surplus, and a Fight Over Who It's For

The economy keeps handing the Government room it hasn't spent — Q2 growth at 5.7%, exports up a fifth on the year. So the argument now is not whether Singapore can afford to help stretched households, but how, and whether it should be written into law. The Workers' Party has put its bid on the table early: legislate retrenchment benefits, and account for the surplus. On 23 August the Prime Minister has to answer with a number.

A full Treasury sharpens a question it cannot buy its way out of. On 4 August the Workers' Party tabled a parliamentary motion setting out its economic vision in response to the Government's Economic Strategy Review, with Pritam Singh pressing two demands: legislate mandatory retrenchment benefits, and give a clearer account of public spending "as the surplus widens."¹ It lands two days after a National Day Message in which Lawrence Wong called families "stretched" between children, ageing parents and work, flagged AI's job anxiety, and promised a "major review" of family support — details deferred to the National Day Rally on 23 August at ITE College Central.² The backdrop has only firmed the case that money exists: advance Q2 growth of 5.7% year on year, non-oil domestic exports up 20.7% in June, and a MAS that in late July nudged its policy-band slope up slightly, expecting core inflation to step up from July before easing through 2027.³

For a comfortable household the read is where the two bids meet: the WP wants structural, legislated protection against the very AI-and-restructuring risk Wong named, while the Government prefers targeted support and one-off relief.¹ The Rally is where that choice becomes concrete — a strong year converted into recurring family relief (leave, childcare-fee caps, a standing top-up) or bankable one-offs that flatter a Budget and fade.² Prior rounds of vouchers have not shifted a fertility rate near 0.97 — so the bar on the 23rd is a number that changes a behaviour, not a headline that soothes one.⁴

23 Aug

NATIONAL DAY RALLY — WHERE A WIDENING SURPLUS, AN OPPOSITION BILL TO LEGISLATE RETRENCHMENT BENEFITS, AND A "MAJOR REVIEW" OF FAMILY SUPPORT ALL HAVE TO ARRIVE WITH A FIGURE ATTACHED. CAPACITY IS NOT THE EXCUSE; INTENT IS THE TEST.²

SG61 • THE SURPLUS FIGHT

RALLY: 23 AUG

RETRENCHMENT BILL TABLED

THE CHATTER — THE COST OF EVERYTHING, AND THE SURPLUS NOBODY CAN SEE

The comment-carrying coverage — The Independent Singapore, MustShareNews — surfaces two notes under every NDR-preview: cost-of-living fatigue, and a weary "another review; show us the money at the Rally."⁵ The WP's line, that a widening surplus deserves a clearer accounting, lands on the affluent reader's own suspicion — that a Government on healthy reserves and a hot economy can do more than top-ups.¹

THE SCEPTIC — A STRONG YEAR IS A REASON TO PAY, NOT PROOF COSTS TURNED

Don't let the surplus do the argument's work. Sociologist Teo You Yenn's 2026 book *Unease: Life in Singapore Families* frames the gap as structural inequality that targeted transfers won't close — a ready contrarian to any Rally that answers "stretched households" with another round of cash.⁴ And the 5.7% print is an advance estimate, year on year off a soft base and led by trade-exposed manufacturing — a reason the Treasury can pay, not evidence a household's costs have eased.³ The falsifier is a Rally that defers specifics to Budget 2027, or a retrenchment-benefit bill left as a motion rather than a law. Watch the fortnight, not the fireworks.

SOURCES 1 Workers' Party parliamentary motion, 4 Aug 2026 — economic vision responding to the Government's Economic Strategy Review (late Jun 2026); Pritam Singh pressed for legislating mandatory retrenchment benefits and clarity on spending "as the surplus widens" — Yahoo News SG; SCMP; We The Citizens. 2 PM Wong's National Day Message, 8 Aug 2026 — families "stretched," AI job anxiety, a "major review" of family support; details deferred to the Rally, 23 Aug at ITE College Central — PMO; Mothership; The Star; Malay Mail. 3 Q2 2026 advance GDP +5.7% y/y, June NODX +20.7%; MAS MPS 27 Jul 2026 — slight policy-band slope increase, core inflation stepping up from July — SingStat; MAS; The Edge. 4 Cost of living — Singapore among Asia's costliest cities (2026); TFR -0.97; Teo You Yenn, *Unease: Life in Singapore Families* (Ethos, 2026) — Numbeo; Ethos Books. 5 Community read — comment-carrying coverage (The Independent SG; MustShareNews) — not verbatim-quoted — flagged.

PROPERTY • THE PIPELINE

The State Keeps Feeding the Fringe — and That's the Ceiling

Two Confirmed-List sites are on the tender block, one of them a 1,010-unit mega-plot pressed against Bedok MRT. For an owner, the supply story is the quiet one that matters: the Government is keeping the city-fringe pipeline full even as prices split by region, and every future OCR launch is a cap on the last one's upside. The million-dollar-flat record is still setting headlines; the land tenders are setting the price.

Supply is where the real signal sits, and the state is not letting the fringe run dry. URA has put two Confirmed-List residential sites out to tender: New Upper Changi Road — some 331,000 square feet, up to ~1,010 units, fronting Bedok MRT — closing at noon on 1 September, and Berlayer Drive — ~272,000 square feet, ~415 units, in the Greater Southern Waterfront near Telok Blangah — which closed on 4 August.¹ Consultants pencil in four-to-seven bids apiece, with top bids around S\$1,350–1,450 psf ppr for Bedok and S\$1,400–1,500 for Berlayer.¹ Roughly 1,425 combined units in mature, MRT-linked locations is the Government doing what it has said it would — keep the outside-central pipeline full — and that is precisely what caps how far the next OCR launch can price above the last.²

The demand side, meanwhile, is genuinely two-speed. The Q2 private index rose just 0.5% overall — but core-central prices firmed about 2.0% while the rest-of-central region fell around 1.4% and the outer

region slipped, so the average hides a widening split.³ In HDB resale the paradox holds: the resale index fell for a second straight quarter (~202.7 flash), yet June set a record 188 million-dollar flats, and July resale volume jumped 24.5% on the month to a 2026 high of ~2,660 after the private-downgrader wait-out was lifted.⁴ For a multi-property owner the read-through is unromantic: the top-end record is a top-decile event, not a floor under a heartland four-room, and the softness is concentrating in rest-of-central private — exactly where an investor tends to sit. Not investment advice.³

~1,010

UNITS ON THE NEW UPPER CHANGI ROAD PLOT FRONTING BEDOK MRT — TENDER CLOSES 1 SEP. WITH BERLAYER'S ~415, THE STATE IS TOPPING UP THE CITY-FRINGE PIPELINE, AND FUTURE SUPPLY IS THE CEILING ON FUTURE OCR PRICES.¹

SUPPLY-LED 1 SEP IS THE TEST

TWO-SPEED DEMAND

THE CHATTER — "WE LIVE IN A TIMELINE WHERE THIS IS NORMAL"

The million-dollar flat is still the argument the boards can't drop. On HardwareZone's EDMW and CNA's threads the recurring lines are resignation and anger in one breath — "\$1.5m HDB in Boon Keng: we live in a timeline where this is normal" set against a persistent counter that these deals remain a small minority and "are not an easy sell."⁵ On the supply story the sober regulars read the twin tenders the way the analysts do: the pipeline stays full, so nobody on the boards expects a heartland melt-up — or a policy lurch.⁵

THE SCEPTIC — A VOLUME SPIKE IS NOT A DEMAND SURGE

Resist the tidy reading of July's jump. Analysts cautioned that the 24.5% resale-volume spike likely reflects BTO-exercise timing and seasonal normalisation after a lull, not a demand resurgence — and the median resale price kept easing while it happened.⁴ Million-dollar flats are still under 9% of transactions, and older resale stock carries rising lease-decay risk that a record headline conveniently omits.⁵ The falsifier for the supply read is the 1 September Bedok field: a thin turnout at a prime, MRT-fronting plot would say developer caution has hardened past discipline into a flinch. Watch the tender, not the record. Not investment advice.¹

SOURCES 1 URA Confirmed-List GLS (pr26-38) — New Upper Changi Road: ~331,198 sq ft, ~1,010 units, beside Bedok MRT, tender closes 1 Sep 2026; Berlayer Drive: ~271,932 sq ft, ~415 units, Telok Blangah, closed 4 Aug 2026; consultant estimates ~4–7 bids, top ~S\$1,350–1,450 psf ppr (Bedok) / ~S\$1,400–1,500 (Berlayer) — URA; The Edge; Realion/Stacked Homes. 2 Read-through — the state keeping the OCR pipeline full caps future OCR upside (desk analysis, not investment advice). 3 Q2 2026 URA private RPI +0.5% q/q; CCR ~+2.0%, RCR ~-1.4%, OCR ~-0.2%; 1H +1.4% — URA flash (pr26-51); CBRE; ERA. 4 HDB — resale index second straight q/q fall (~202.7 flash); June record 188 million-dollar flats (~8.8%); July volume +24.5% m/m to ~2,660 (2026 high) after the wait-out lifted, median ~S\$635k, prices still easing; analysts flag BTO-timing/seasonal — 99.co/SRX; Stacked Homes; HDB flash (verify vs HDB). 5 Community — HardwareZone/EDMW, CNA threads (normalisation vs affordability anger; "not an easy sell") — summarised — flagged.

TECHNOLOGY • THE LOOPHOLE

Washington Finally Names the Back Door: Renting the Chips It Won't Sell

You can't buy a restricted Nvidia card into China. You can, it turns out, rent one by the hour in Bangkok or Kuala Lumpur — and Chinese AI firms have. This week the US moved on that: the Commerce Department's export arm is drawing up lists of where Blackwell-class compute is being tapped remotely, alongside a House bill to make the rental itself illegal. The catch is that, right now, it isn't.

Export controls stop a chip crossing a border; they do not stop a login. Around 7 August, reporting said the Bureau of Industry and Security is now systematically reviewing how Chinese AI firms legally reach restricted Nvidia chips offshore — renting Blackwell-generation compute by the hour in third countries such as Thailand and Malaysia, where the physical-export rules don't bite.¹ BIS is said to be building two lists: countries running black-market physical diversion into China, and countries where Chinese firms access the silicon remotely — the second unusual because remote access is not, at present, illegal.¹ Named in scope: Alibaba, Tencent, ByteDance and Moonshot. It runs alongside the House-passed Remote Access Security Act, which would extend export controls to cloud and remote access — and builds on May's rule requiring licences for China-headquartered entities and their overseas subsidiaries.²

The honest read is that this is naming, not yet enforcing. Because renting overseas compute is legal

until the Act clears the Senate, the BIS lists are signalling — a map of the back door published to deter the traffic through it — more than a switch that closes it.¹ And the strategic risk cuts the other way: Nvidia has already lost effectively its whole China shipment share, policing overseas rental is near-unenforceable without allied buy-in, and squeezing remote access harder pushes Chinese demand onto domestic Huawei and Cambricon silicon — accelerating the very decoupling the controls meant to delay.³ For the home-lab reader, tighter control of Blackwell abroad is the backdrop to what a 5090 you own is worth (p8).³

2 lists

BIS IS REPORTEDLY DRAWING — ONE FOR PHYSICAL DIVERSION INTO CHINA, ONE FOR OFFSHORE REMOTE ACCESS TO BLACKWELL-CLASS CHIPS. THE SECOND NAMES A LOOPHOLE THAT IS STILL, TODAY, ENTIRELY LEGAL.¹

THE RENT-A-GPU GAP

SIGNALLING, NOT ENFORCING

BLACKWELL ABROAD

THE CHATTER — "THE LOOPHOLE EVERYONE KNEW ABOUT, FINALLY NAMED"

Semiconductor and policy commentators — Tom's Hardware, the r/hardware read — frame the review as the open secret finally getting an official name: everyone in the trade knew Chinese labs were renting restricted compute in Southeast Asia; a BIS list is the tell the door is being watched.⁴ The recurring caveat is enforceability — that "remote access is legal" makes this a signal until the Senate acts, and that without Thailand and Malaysia policing their own data centres, a list is a warning, not a wall.⁴

THE SCEPTIC — THE CONTROL MAY SPEED THE DECOUPLING IT MEANT TO SLOW

Hold the crackdown to its likely effect. Chasing overseas GPU rental is a near-unenforceable game of whack-a-mole across sovereign jurisdictions, and Nvidia's China shipment share is already gone — so the marginal Chinese buyer this squeezes is the one who was going to try Huawei's Ascend or Cambricon anyway.³ Push hard enough and the controls manufacture exactly the domestic-silicon demand they exist to prevent, while allied cloud providers wear the compliance cost. Signalling has value; treating a list of countries as if it were a working export ban does not. The falsifier is simple — watch whether the Senate acts, and whether any third country actually restricts a Chinese tenant.²

SOURCES¹ US Bureau of Industry and Security reviewing offshore access to restricted Nvidia chips (reported ~7 Aug 2026) — Chinese AI firms renting Blackwell-class compute by the hour in third countries (Thailand, Malaysia); BIS building two lists (physical diversion; remote access), the latter novel because remote access is not currently illegal; firms in scope: Alibaba, Tencent, ByteDance, Moonshot — Bloomberg (paywalled); Reuters; TechTimes (7 Aug 2026). ² House-passed Remote Access Security Act (extends controls to cloud/remote access); May 2026 rule licensing China-HQ'd entities incl. overseas subsidiaries — Tom's Hardware; Communications Today. ³ Strategic read — Nvidia already lost ~all China shipment share; policing overseas rental near-unenforceable without allied buy-in; risk of accelerating a shift to Huawei/Cambricon — desk analysis; Tom's Hardware. Not investment advice. ⁴ Community read — Tom's Hardware, r/hardware ("the loophole everyone knew about, finally named"; enforceability scepticism) — summarised from reporting — flagged.

THE HOME LAB • THE 5090 QUESTION

What a Single — and a Dual — RTX 5090 Actually Runs

The reader's rig is the whole point of this page. With 32GB on one card and 64GB on two, the questions turn practical: which weights load, how a 120-billion model runs on silicon too small to hold it, and when a second 5090 stops adding speed and starts adding room. Cheap-card numbers don't apply here.

The week clarified what the reader's card is actually for. Meta's Muse Glimmer — 30 billion parameters, Apache-2.0, sized to about 24GB — is not a chatbot to beat the frontier; it is built for always-on *local agents*: function-calling, long tool-use sessions, local coding, LLM-as-judge.¹ On a single 5090's 32GB it runs at Q6 or Q8 with context headroom to spare; on a matched dual-5090 you push it toward FP16 or run several agents in parallel — the job a rented API can't do behind your own firewall.¹ The card also punches above its capacity on sparse weights: OpenAI's gpt-oss-120B (116.8B total, ~5.1B firing per token, ~59GB at MXFP4) does not fit in VRAM, yet runs via expert-offload — attention on the GPU, the experts spilled to system RAM via llama.cpp's `--n-cpu-moe` — at roughly 47 tokens a second.² Sparsity, not raw capacity, is how 32GB reaches a 120-billion model at all.²

Against that, the flagship the reader was told to wait for is still a benchmark PDF. Alibaba promised open weights for its Qwen3.8-27B (and the 2.4-trillion, ~95B-active Max) during the week of 10 August; at the deadline there was nothing on Hugging Face, no licence named, no architecture and no new date — placeholder repos, no safetensors.³ Grade it 17 August. The tooling, meanwhile, quietly improved: the August Ollama build fixed stalled downloads and bumped its bundled llama.cpp engine, and the vLLM 0.21 line stabilised Blackwell inference — with one catch that reads like an advertisement for this rig, its tensor-parallel path *requires identical GPUs*, a clean fit for a matched dual-5090 and a wall for a mixed bag.⁴ Where 64GB earns its place stays the same: 30-to-40B work split across both cards, 70B at four-bit with a real context window, and QLoRA fine-tuning up to the 50-to-60-billion range.²

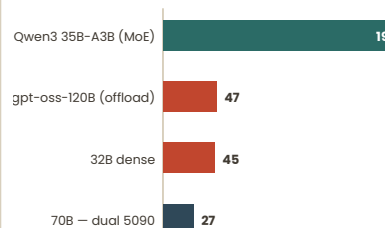
THE STACK — THREE TOOLS, THREE JOBS

The settled toolkit: **vLLM** for throughput (FP8, tensor-parallel across a matched pair — identical cards only); **llama.cpp** for control (`--tensor-split`, and the MoE CPU-offload that makes gpt-oss-120B run at all); and **ExLlamaV2 / TabbyAPI** for EXL2 quants. The read on r/LocalLLaMA and HN this week: genuine relief that Meta "came back to open weights" with something agent-shaped that fits one card, and matching impatience with Qwen — "promised weights, delivered a benchmark." The standing caveat holds: "dual-5090 equals a single H100 at a fraction of the cost" is true for capacity, false for bandwidth, because PCIe eats the gains.⁴

SOURCES 1 Muse Glimmer — 30B open-weight (Apache-2.0), ~10 Aug 2026, built for local agents; fits a single RTX 5090 (32GB) at Q6/Q8 with context headroom, near-FP16 or parallel agents on a matched dual-5090 — Meta AI Research; dev.to; Thunder Compute, Aug 2026 (see p7). 2 Single RTX 5090 (32GB): gpt-oss-120B (116.8B total, 5.1B active/token, ~59GB MXFP4) via expert-offload (llama.cpp `--n-cpu-moe`) ~47 tok/s; 32B dense Q4 ~45 tok/s; dual 5090 (64GB) fits 70B Q4 (~42GB)+context, PCIe x8/x8 caps scaling ~1.4–1.6x, 70B ~27 tok/s (~single-H100 at ~\$7,600 vs \$25k+); earns it on 30–40B split, 70B+context, QLoRA to ~50–60B — llama.cpp #15396; DatabaseMart, 2026 (secondary benchmarks, directional — flagged). 3 Qwen3.8-27B/Max open weights promised the week of 10 Aug 2026 — nothing on Hugging Face at the deadline, no licence/date, placeholder repos (grade 17 Aug) — digitalapplied; byteiota; HN #49150809. 4 Tooling — Aug Ollama build (fixed downloads, llama.cpp bump); vLLM 0.21 stabilised Blackwell, tensor-parallel requires identical GPUs (dual-5090 fit) — Releasebot; Spheron, 2026. Not hardware-purchase advice.

Tokens / second, home-lab weights

single 5090 unless noted · four-bit / MXFP4 · measured, directly



Sparsity beats capacity: an MoE where few experts fire per token outruns a dense 70B split across two cards.

Sources: Ollama/llama.cpp Discussion #15396; practitioner posts, Aug 2026.

A Meridian chart. Figures are secondary benchmark posts, not first-party — directional, not gospel.

5.1B

OF 116.8B PARAMETERS FIRE PER TOKEN IN GPT-OSS-120B — WHY A MODEL TOO BIG FOR 32GB STILL RUNS AT ~47 TOK/S ON ONE 5090 VIA EXPERT-OFFLOAD.²

WHERE 64GB EARNS IT

QLoRA to ~50–60B — training that a single 32GB card simply cannot hold.²

70B + real context — four-bit weights with room for a long window, not a toy one.²

THE KIT • THE WAIT, RESOLVED

The 360 We Told You to Wait On Is Here — Keep Waiting a Fortnight

Last issue this desk flagged the Insta360 X6 and said: don't buy until a lab measures it. It went on sale on our cover date, 12 August, at US\$699 — a real US\$150 jump on the X5. The first hands-on footage is promising. The lab numbers still do not exist. For a buy-once buyer that is the entire verdict, unchanged: it is probably the class leader, and nobody has proven it yet.

The wait ended, and the counsel didn't change. Pre-orders for the X6 opened 12 August on Amazon and B&H — US\$699 standard, US\$769 for the Essentials bundle — on a genuine capability step: dual one-inch-class custom Sony sensors, 8K/50fps 360, a dedicated AI chip, up to ~140 minutes of battery, and Panomind on-device processing, in a more compact body than the X5.¹ The footage doing the rounds is creator hands-on, not a measured teardown: at filing there is no RTINGS, DPReview or TechRadar lab review, because the camera is a day old.² So the buy-once reader inherits exactly the position we left him in a week ago — the class leader, on paper, still on the honour system.²

Two footnotes for the patient. Insta360's "one-inch" has historically meant one-inch-type (leaks split on

whether the X6's is a true 1.0" or a 1/1.1"), and stitched 360 throws away resolution at the seam — so 8K-360 is not 8K flat, and the low-light gain the marketing leans on is precisely what a lab exists to measure.² None of that makes it a bad camera; it makes day-one a bet. The reader who buys on 26 August, after RTINGS posts its low-light and dynamic-range numbers, pays the same US\$699 and carries none of the risk of being the test unit.²

\$699

LAUNCH PRICE OF THE X6 STANDARD BUNDLE (US\$769 ESSENTIALS) — A ~US\$150 JUMP ON THE X5, DUAL ONE-INCH-CLASS SENSORS AND 8K/50, ON SALE 12 AUG, STILL UN-LAB-TESTED AT FILING.¹

ON SALE 12 AUG

STILL: WAIT FOR THE LAB

+\$150 ON THE X5

THE CHATTER — A TRUE ONE-INCH 360 AT LAST, AND A PRICE GRUMBLE

The 360-camera community (r/Insta360, the ThreeSixtyCameras crowd) is genuinely excited that a real one-inch-class 360 has finally arrived — but two notes recur under the launch clips: the US\$150 jump from the X5's US\$549, and open scepticism about whether "1-inch" means a true 1.0" sensor or Insta360's usual 1-inch-type.² The consensus is "promising, verdict pending," which is also this desk's. (Community read from launch-day threads and first-looks, not a single quoted post — flagged.)²

THE SCEPTIC — "SHIPPING" IS NOT "PROVEN"

Strip the launch and the X6 is an iteration on a formula Insta360 already leads: bigger sensors, an AI chip, a smaller shell. Every headline spec is a maker claim until a lab measures it, and stitched-360 resolution has a long history of dissolving into soft, noisy pixels once the seam is accounted for.² The reader on an X4 or X5 has no new peg beyond "newer." The one who wants it should let the reviewers be the test unit — the price will be the same in a fortnight, and the numbers won't.

STILL ON THE SHELF

Snap's consumer "Specs" — Snap is pushing its first consumer AR glasses for 2026 (slimmer body, ~4hr battery, wider field of view), but with no firm price or on-sale date it

Samsung's Galaxy Glasses — still leak-stage (a rumoured ~\$379–499 base, no announced price or ship date). Off the page until Unpacked makes it real.³

¹ Sources buy on Amazon, B&H, US\$699 standard / US\$769 Essentials (up from the X5's US\$549); dual one-inch-class custom Sony sensors (leaks split 1.0" vs 1/1.1"), 8K/50fps 360, dedicated AI chip, ~140-min battery, Panomind on-device processing + Gemini-based cloud edit, auto plate-blur, more compact than the X5 — TheNewCamera (US pricing); Imaging Resource (12 Aug confirm); NotebookCheck; Geeky Gadgets; Gizmochina (retail-box leak), Aug 2026 (pre-launch leaks/maker claims; independent lab review not yet published — flagged). ² Lab status — no RTINGS/DPReview/TechRadar review at filing (launch day); only creator hands-on + first test footage; "1-inch" historically = 1-inch-type; stitched 360 sheds resolution at the seam — DigitalCameraWorld; community threads (r/Insta360, ThreeSixtyCameras), summarised, not a single quoted post — flagged. ³ Snap consumer "Specs" (2026; slimmer, ~4hr, wider FOV — no firm price/date); Samsung Galaxy Glasses (leak-stage, ~\$379–499 rumoured, no announced price/ship) — TipRanks; The Gadgeteer; Geeky Gadgets; TechAdvisor, 2026 (leak-tier — demoted). The Garmin subject remains off the desk per standing directive.

THE GOOD LIFE · THE OBJECT

The House That Claims It Invented the Chronograph Rings the Bell in Champagne

Louis Moinet marks the 210th anniversary of its founder's Compteur de Tierces — arguably the first true chronograph — with a warm two-tone version of the 1816: an in-house column-wheel chronograph in grade-5 titanium, CHF 28,900. It is the purest buy-once proposition on the desk this week: a genuinely integrated movement at featherweight, from an independent whose whole pitch is that it got there first. The catch is everything a small maker can't offer.

Buy the movement, and buy the story it comes with. To mark 210 years since Louis Moinet's Compteur de Tierces — the counter many horologists credit as the first true chronograph — the house has given its 1816 Chronograph a golden-champagne dial.¹ The 40.6mm case is grade-5 titanium, a double-gadroon of 51 parts; under the sapphire back sits the LM816, a hand-wound, integrated column-wheel chronograph developed in-house — 330 components, 4Hz, a 48-hour reserve.¹ The price, CHF 28,900 excluding tax, is not small; a properly integrated chronograph at titanium weight usually costs far more.¹

For a buy-once collector the appeal is exactly that integration: not a modular chronograph bolted onto a base calibre but a movement conceived as one,

from a house that trades on inventing the complication.² Fratello's hands-on calls it a genuine in-house column-wheel chrono at a weight a steel rival can't match; the champagne two-tone splits the room, warm to some, fussy to others.² The honest counterweight is scale: Louis Moinet is a low-volume independent, its resale liquidity and service network thin next to a Lange or a JLC — so CHF 29k asks you to buy the inventor story as much as the watch.²

330

COMPONENTS IN THE IN-HOUSE LM816 COLUMN-WHEEL CHRONOGRAPH — A MOVEMENT BUILT AS ONE PIECE, IN GRADE-5 TITANIUM, CHF 28,900. THE INTEGRATION IS THE POINT; THE THIN RESALE IS THE PRICE.¹

IN-HOUSE CHRONO

TITANIUM · 40.6MM

THE INVENTOR'S CLAIM

THE CHATTER — THE INDEPENDENTS' DARLING, WITH AN ASTERISK

Among watch writers the 1816 is a repeat favourite from the independents — Monochrome and Fratello both flag a genuinely integrated column-wheel chrono at this weight as rare value in absolute terms, whatever CHF 29k sounds like.² The comment read splits on the champagne dial and circles the worry every low-volume independent draws: what servicing and reselling one looks like in ten years. Admired as watchmaking; bought with eyes open on liquidity.²

THE SCEPTIC — PROVENANCE PRESTIGE IS NOT RESALE VALUE

Separate the movement from the marketing. The LM816 is real and impressive; the "we invented the chronograph" framing is a brand asset, not a spec, and does nothing for the two things a buy-once buyer should weigh — service access and exit liquidity.² At CHF 29k a Lange or a used Datograph offers a deeper network and a thicker resale market. Buy the 1816 because the chronograph and the titanium delight you, not because it will hold its price. A collector's caution, not an endorsement.²

STILL ON THE SHELF

TAG Heuer Formula 1 Solargraph "Zandvoort" — a motorsport peg for the final Dutch GP: 38mm steel, solar movement, orange accents, two LEs (1,500 + 1,000 pieces), from ~€2,100 / US\$2,150. But solar quartz in an LE wrapper

rarely earns collectibility; likely to trade at or under retail once the GP cycle passes. Ties to the F1 (p19).³

Meze ARTA — the Romanian house's US\$6,000 flagship planar, fully rebuildable, "sounds more like a supercar"

(TechRadar). A grail can, held from its High End Vienna peg.³

SOURCES 1 Louis Moinet 1816 Chronograph "Champagne" — marks 210 years since the Compteur de Tierces; 40.6mm case (51 parts); in-house hand-wound LM816 column-wheel chronograph, 330 components, 4Hz, 48h reserve; champagne dial, 12h counter at 6; integrated titanium bracelet; CHF 28,900 excl. tax; two-tone iteration of the 2025 W&W debut — Monochrome-Watches; Fratello (hands-on, 10 Aug 2026); WristReview; Watch Advice; louismoynet.com. 2 Reception — praise for an integrated in-house chrono at titanium weight; champagne two-tone divides; low-volume independent = thin resale/service vs Lange/JLC — Fratello; Monochrome; Watch Collecting Lifestyle, 2026 (comment read, summarised). 3 TAG Heuer Formula 1 Solargraph "Zandvoort" LE (10–11 Aug 2026) — 38mm steel, solar movement, orange accents; two LEs (1,500 + 1,000 pcs); €2,100/€2,200, US\$2,150 — Fratello; Hypebeast; Oracle of Time; Retail Jeweller. Meze ARTA — US\$6,000 planar (TechRadar), held from High End Vienna.

SCREEN & SOUND · NEW MUSIC FRIDAY

A Reggaetón Superstar Softens, and the Critics' Pick Sneaks Past Her

Two albums landed on 7 August pulling in opposite directions: Karol G's atmospheric heartbreak record, carrying her first-ever Drake collaboration into the pop-blockbuster slot, and Ravyn Lenae's *Blue Island*, the quieter release the reviewers actually rated highest. It is the recurring culture-desk lesson — the biggest launch and the best-reviewed one are rarely the same record — and, two days out, an album filed at acclaim it hasn't yet had to defend.

The week's real music story is a split-screen. Karol G released *No Me Arrepiento de Sentir Tanto* on 7 August — a fourteen-track heartbreak cycle, her sixth album, and the pop event of the fortnight for one detail above the rest: her first-ever official Drake collaboration, alongside a Bruno Mars feature.¹ Reviews ran generally positive — Consequence called it "a superstar moment" — with a persistent strand finding the atmospheric turn "too mild" for the reggaetón crowd that made her.¹ The quieter release out the same day is the one the critics rated higher: Ravyn Lenae's *Blue Island*, named for her Chicago-area hometown, landed a Metacritic 78 ("generally favorable"), with an 80 from the Guardian and a 71 from Pitchfork — the R&B follow-up to her breakout "Love Me Not," and the record reviewers are calling the week's real find.²

Friday still belongs to a bigger name in waiting. Phoebe Bridgers' *Lost Weekend* — sixteen tracks, her first solo album since *Punisher* — lands 14 August

carrying an advance acclaim the public hasn't heard a note of; the audience verdict, and whether it holds, is a next-week story (gradeable around 28 August).³ And the summer tentpole keeps compounding: *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* passed roughly US\$1.67–1.7 billion worldwide by mid-month — a delta this desk logs but does not re-litigate, its record opening settled and corrected back in No. 67.⁴ The film earned the harder verdict a launch can't give — legs — on a Metacritic that sits, tellingly, right on the Holland-Spider-Man average.⁴

78

METACRITIC FOR RAVYN LENAЕ'S *BLUE ISLAND* — THE BEST-REVIEWED RELEASE OF THE WEEK, AND NOT THE ONE TOPPING THE CHARTS. THE GAP BETWEEN THE BIGGEST LAUNCH AND THE BEST RECORD IS THE DESK'S STANDING LESSON.²

KAROL G × DRAKE

LENAE: CRITICS' PICK

BRIDGERS: FRIDAY

THE CHATTER — THE SPLIT THE RELEASES OPENED

The critics and the fanbases are pulling apart in public. R&B writers rave over Lenae's pop-groove pivot — NME and Rolling Stone treat *Blue Island* as an arrival — while reggaetón fans split over Karol G softening into atmospheric pop, the Drake team-up read as either a coronation or a sell-out depending on the thread.¹ Under it all sits the Bridgers pre-release euphoria: near-unanimous advance praise on an album nobody outside the press has heard, which is precisely the setup for a critic-versus-listener split once Friday's streaming numbers land.³

THE SCEPTIC — A FIRST-WEEK NUMBER IS NOT A VERDICT

Hold each release to what's actually been tested. Karol G's opening week will be enormous and will tell you about her fanbase, not the record's staying power; the "superstar moment" framing is a launch narrative until the songs settle into rotation or don't.¹ Bridgers' advance acclaim draws on the specialists first in line — the audience settle is a fortnight away, and a sixteen-track return after six years has the length to divide a devoted base.³ And "biggest ever" for the blockbuster needs a live tracker, not a memory, which is why this desk corrected its own opening-weekend claim two issues back. Enjoy the week; hold the coronations.⁴

SOURCES 1 Karol G, *No Me Arrepiento de Sentir Tanto* — out 7 Aug 2026 (Bichota/Interscope), 14 tracks; features her first official Drake collaboration + Bruno Mars; reviews generally positive ("a superstar moment," Consequence) with a "too mild" strand — UPI (7 Aug); Consequence; Rolling Stone, Aug 2026 (Metacritic aggregate still settling — qualitative). 2 Ravyn Lenae, *Blue Island* — out 7 Aug 2026; Metacritic 78 ("generally favorable," 8 critics), Guardian 80, Pitchfork 71, Paste 75; follow-up to breakout "Love Me Not," named for her Chicago-area hometown — Album of the Year/Metacritic; NME; Rolling Stone, Aug 2026. 3 Phoebe Bridgers, *Lost Weekend* — out 14 Aug 2026 (Dead Oceans), 16 tracks, her first solo LP since *Punisher* (2020); strong advance critical scores; audience/user score pending release (HELD — gradeable ~28 Aug) — Metacritic; Rolling Stone; Variety, Aug 2026. 4 *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* (dir. Destin Daniel Cretton) — ~US\$1.67–1.7B worldwide by mid-Aug (~US\$655M domestic / ~US\$1.01B international), 2026's global No. 1; RT ~92% / Metacritic ~70 (on the Holland-Spider-Man average); record opening established + corrected in No. 67, not re-litigated — Variety; Screen Daily; The Wrap, Aug 2026.

THE FAMILY DESK • THE AGE THAT MATTERS

The Screen-Time Rulebook Grew Up — and It Points Straight at Eleven

This year the American Academy of Pediatrics retired its decade-old "hours per day" limit, shifting to what and how over how much. But the newer research adds a sharper edge the headlines miss: the harm signal from social media is not a flat line across childhood. It concentrates in early adolescence, and it runs stronger in girls — which puts an eleven-year-old daughter squarely in the highest-signal window. General guidance, not medical advice.

The official advice just stopped counting hours, and the reason matters. This year America's pediatric academy — the AAP — dropped the decade-old "hours per day" rule, moving to guidance built on context and content: *what* a child is doing on a screen and *how*, not merely how long.¹ Underneath that shift sits a finding parents should carry: a 2026 meta-analysis of 153 longitudinal studies found the social-media-harm association is strongest in early adolescence and stronger in girls than boys, and a South-Korean longitudinal study found heavier smartphone use predicted more depressive symptoms in girls but not boys, with the timing of puberty moderating the effect.² The signal is not evenly spread across a childhood; it clusters in the eleven-to-thirteen band — which is exactly where a Singapore parent with an eleven-year-old daughter now stands.²

The practical read is not a lock but a target. If the highest-signal window is early-adolescent girls, then the years around eleven are when the unglamorous defaults earn their keep: protect sleep by keeping the phone out of the bedroom overnight, know what she actually watches and messages rather than tracking a clock, and hold one regular ritual that isn't a screen.³ None of that is a ban, and that is the point — the research that dropped the hourly cap also killed the

idea that any single number parents a child for you.¹ Continuity-wise, it also reframes last issue's Australian experiment: a hard external wall may matter less than *which* child, at *which* age, is behind it.⁴

11–13

THE EARLY-ADOLESCENT BAND WHERE THE 2026 META-ANALYSIS OF 153 STUDIES FOUND THE SOCIAL-MEDIA-HARM SIGNAL STRONGEST — AND STRONGER IN GIRLS THAN BOYS. NOT A FLAT LINE ACROSS CHILDHOOD; A WINDOW.²

AAP: HOURS RETIRED

THE 11–13 WINDOW

NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

Keep the caution in the open with the finding. These are associations from longitudinal data, not proof that a given hour harmed a given child, and the girls-and-early-adolescence pattern is a population signal, not a diagnosis of your daughter.² The honest use of it is directional: it tells a parent *when* to pay closest attention, not that a phone will make a specific child unwell. Page 13 takes the deliberately calming voice the ban debate keeps under-quoting — and the one new conversation that has genuinely changed.³

STILL ON THE WIRE

Australia's ban, 8 months on — the regulator (eSafety) found more than 8 in 10 under-16s still using social media; the commissioner is investigating Meta, Snap, TikTok and YouTube for non-compliance, with no fines yet.⁴

THE CHATTER — "DELAY THE PHONE" VS "TEACH, DON'T BAN"

The parenting world has hardened into two camps, and the new AAP guidance lands between them. "Delay the smartphone" movements (Wait Until 8th, Smartphone Free Childhood) read the early-adolescent-girls signal as vindication for holding the device back; the AAP's pivot to context over hours arms the "teach, don't ban" parents who want to supervise rather than prohibit.¹ The Australian regulator's finding — a national ban barely dented use — sits awkwardly across both, read as "start earlier" or "bans don't work." The refrain in each: the law was the easy part; the daily judgment is the hard one.⁴

SOURCES 1 American Academy of Pediatrics dropped its decade-old hourly-limit rule in 2026, shifting to context/content ("how" and "what," not "how much") — The Conversation; MedicalXpress; Techdirt, 22 Jul 2026. 2 2026 meta-analysis of 153 longitudinal studies — harm association strongest in early adolescence, stronger in girls; a South Korean study found heavier smartphone use predicted more depressive symptoms in girls (not boys), moderated by puberty timing — Child Mind Institute; JAMA Pediatrics; PMC, 2026 (associations, not individual causation — flagged). 3 Practical levers — protect sleep, know the content, keep a non-screen ritual; general guidance, not medical advice. 4 Australia's under-16 ban (10 Dec 2025), 8 months on — eSafety found >8 in 10 under-16s still using social media; Commissioner Julie Inman Grant investigating Meta, Snap, TikTok, YouTube, no fines yet; researchers stress parent knowledge over surveillance — Al Jazeera (3 Aug 2026); The Conversation; Griffith University. Not medical or legal advice.

THE TWEEEN YEARS • THE NEW TALK

The Conversation That Changed Isn't About Screen Time — It's About What's Real

Most parents feel ready to talk about strangers and screen limits. Fewer are ready for the version that actually matters now: whether an eleven-year-old can tell an AI-generated image, message or "friend" from a real one. That is the online-safety skill that genuinely shifted this year — and the researchers who study the panic still say to keep your head. General guidance, not medical advice.

The "talk" parents rehearse is a decade out of date. A July 2026 Norton study found that while 85% of parents feel comfortable discussing online risk in general, 32% are not confident their child can tell AI-generated content from the real thing — the exact gap that now matters most.¹ The stakes are not abstract: the Internet Watch Foundation reports that the majority of the self-generated abuse material it sees features eleven-to-thirteen-year-olds, most of them girls, against a steep 2025 surge in AI-generated child-sexual-abuse imagery.¹ For an eleven-year-old the practical curriculum has shifted from "don't talk to strangers" to AI literacy: spotting a deepfake, understanding what a "nudify" app does, recognising a scam DM that reads like a friend.¹ That is the new hygiene, and it slots exactly onto the age band page 12 flagged.²

Now the voice the panic keeps under-quoting. Candice Odgers of UC Irvine and Andrew Przybylski of Oxford — two of the field's most-cited researchers — argue the causal evidence that social media itself drives most teens' mental-health problems is thin, and the effect sizes tiny: Orben and Przybylski's much-quoted finding put social media's share of teen-wellbeing variance at well under 1%, "about the same as eating potatoes or wearing glasses."³ Odgers adds that the strongest predictor of a teen's mental health is caregiver mental health, and that causation often runs the other way — struggling kids use more, rather than the use making them struggle.³ Both cautions can be true at once: teach the AI literacy that genuinely changed, and refuse the headline that turns a modest signal into a verdict. General guidance, not medical advice.³

SOURCES ¹ Norton study (Jul 2026) — 85% of parents comfortable discussing online risk; 32% the app you can't install is a conversation from real; Internet Watch Foundation — majority of self-generated abuse material features 11–13-year-olds, most girls, amid a 2025 surge in AI-generated CSAM — Norton via Yahoo Finance; European Commission child-safety report (13 Jul 2026) / IWF (associations/prevalence as reported). ² Age-band context — see p12 (2026 meta-analysis; harm signal strongest 11–13, stronger in girls). ³ Candice Odgers (UC Irvine) + Andrew Przybylski (Oxford) — causal evidence for social media as a major driver of teen mental-health problems is thin; Orben & Przybylski put social media's share of teen-wellbeing variance well under 1% ("about the same as eating potatoes or wearing glasses"); strongest predictor is caregiver mental health; reverse causation likely; Nature Human Behaviour (2025) shows a condition-dependent picture — TED/NPR coverage; Orben & Przybylski; Nature Human Behaviour (quotes paraphrased from coverage — flagged). General guidance, not medical or legal advice.

THE READ — FOR A SINGAPORE PARENT

Put the two pages together and the durable version is unglamorous and specific: the highest-signal age is the years around eleven, especially for girls (p12); the skill that genuinely shifted is telling real from AI-generated; and the strongest lever remains the home, not the platform.³ Protect sleep, know the content, add "is this real?" to the vocabulary, and treat your own steadiness as the intervention — the version most likely to survive the day a child can route around any block a parent installs.¹

THE SCEPTIC — DON'T BE ALARMIST

The don't-be-alarmist note is the discipline, not a dismissal. The mental-health effect sizes are small and heavily confounded, and a "social media causes X" line rarely survives contact with the language the research actually uses.³ Hold the AI-safety point to the same standard: the IWF and Norton figures are real and worth acting on, but they describe a risk to manage with literacy, not a reason to panic a household into a lockdown that the evidence says lowers a parent's visibility more than a child's use.¹ Teach the skill; keep the perspective.

The new online-safety skill isn't a screen limit. It's the question "is this real?" — and an eleven-year-old needs it now.

THE LEVERS THAT HOLD UP

Protect sleep first — the most consistent finding across the cautious and the calm.³

Teach "is this real?" — deepfakes, "nudify" apps, scam DMs; AI literacy is the new stranger-danger.¹

Keep talking — parent knowledge beats surveillance

software; the app you can't install is a conversation.³

THE MACRO DESK · THE PRINT NOBODY'S SEEN

Oil Wrote the Inflation Scare Before the Data Could

A shut strait and a burning refinery pushed Brent toward US\$88, and the bond market did the rest: the ten-year backed up to a one-month high near 4.70% on a higher-for-longer bid. Yet gold ripped through US\$4,400 anyway — the tell that this is an inflation scare, not a growth one. The July CPI that settles it prints tonight, Singapore time, after this edition. Nothing constructive here is paid for yet. Market explanation, not investment advice.

VWRA ▲ \$194.6	US 10Y ▲ 4.70%	DXY ▲ 99.7	GOLD ▲ \$4,400	BTC ▼ \$64.3k	BRENT ▲ \$88
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Trace the week backward and it begins at a chokepoint. The Strait of Hormuz stayed closed and a reported Houthi strike hit a Saudi Aramco refinery, and oil did what oil does with a supply scare — Brent firmed toward US\$88, WTI toward the low-US\$80s (p3).¹ Higher energy feeds straight into inflation expectations, so the US ten-year yield backed up to a one-month high near 4.70% as the market leaned back toward a Fed that holds *higher for longer*, and the dollar steadied around a DXY of 99.7.² The tell sits in the metals: gold pushed through US\$4,400 to a multi-month high *despite* the rising yields that usually cap it — an inflation-and-haven bid overpowering the real-yield headwind, not a growth story.² Bitcoin, the high-beta read, softened to about US\$64,300 as traders de-risked into the print.²

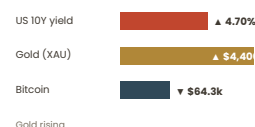
The book now waits on a number it cannot see. July CPI prints tonight Singapore time — 8:30am in New York, after this edition — so treat it as awaiting.³ The two paths are stark: a hot number on top of an oil scare hardens the higher-for-longer bid, firms the dollar, and pressures a record-high equity tape already leaning on air; a soft one lets the yield spike unwind fast, and the trade most exposed to that surprise is a gold sitting at records. The regime: an oil-led inflation scare, dollar firm, yields bid, havens leading. Market explanation, not investment advice; no level here is fabricated.³

THE READ — WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

Into the print, the complex is fighting itself for once. A rise in yields driven by inflation, not growth, is the unhelpful kind — it can mark global equities and global bonds down together, so diversification is working *against* the reader this week. Gold is the cleanest expression of the regime, bid even as real yields rise; bitcoin the thin, high-beta opposite, sold as risk comes off. A soft CPI reverses most of it in a session. Not advice; a map of the sensitivities.³

The inflation-scare fingerprint

weekly direction — gold up while yields up



with yields is the tell: an inflation-and-haven bid, not growth. Source: TradingEconomics; Fortune, 11 Aug.

A Meridian chart. Directional, not to scale. Not investment advice.

\$4,400

GOLD PUSHING THROUGH US\$4,400 WHILE THE TEN-YEAR ROSE — THE COMBINATION THAT MARKS AN INFLATION-AND-HAVEN SCARE RATHER THAN A GROWTH STORY.²

INFLATION SCARE

HIGHER-FOR-LONGER

AWAITING CPI

THE SCEPTIC — A SCARE IS NOT A FORECAST

An oil-driven yield spike can unwind as fast as it arrived if tonight's CPI lands soft, and a gold at record highs is the crowded trade a dovish surprise punishes first.³ The Aramco-strike detail is single-region-sourced; several levels cleared on one feed. Explaining a move is not endorsing it; never bank a level you can't verify.²

SOURCES 1 Oil — Hormuz still shut (p3); a reported Houthi strike on a Saudi Aramco refinery (~9 Aug, single-region-sourced — flagged); Brent ~US\$88, WTI ~\$83.5 — TradingEconomics; Fortune; Investing.com, 11 Aug 2026. 2 Market strip, Tue 11 Aug 2026 US session: VWRA ~\$194.6, BNDW ~67.53, US 10Y ~4.70% (one-month high), DXY ~99.7, USD/SGD ~1.280, USD/JPY ~159.3, gold >US\$4,400 (multi-month high), BTC ~\$64,300 — TradingEconomics; stockanalysis.com; Yahoo Finance; Fortune. Precise all-time-high gold figure held; several levels single-sourced. 3 US July CPI due 12 Aug 08:30 ET (20:30 SGT, after this edition) — awaiting; a hot print hardens higher-for-longer/firms the dollar, a soft one unwinds the yield spike (Finimize: "yields tick up as traders wait on CPI") — BLS; Finimize; Yahoo Finance. Regime read — desk analysis. Market explanation, NOT investment advice; no level fabricated.

THE RABBIT HOLE · THE WHEEL

The Screen-Free Craft Where You Don't Own the Result Until It Survives Two Fires

Studio ceramics is clay spun on a powered wheel and braced into shape by hand — and then the hard part, because a pot isn't yours until it lives through a bisque firing and a glaze firing at up to 1,300°C. The hook is a single silent moment; the reality is a two-fire gauntlet, a kiln most apartments can't run, and a boom of mid-career professionals hunting a counterweight to a life lived on screens.

The whole hobby turns on one silent moment: centering. You lean a wet lump of clay onto a spinning wheel, brace your arms against your body, and press — and the instant the wobbling mass goes still and true under your palms is the meditative, tactile, screen-free high that every potter names as the gateway.¹ But wheel-throwing is only the romantic on-ramp. Every piece then travels the same unforgiving pipeline — wet clay, trimmed at leather-hard, dried to bone-dry greenware, a first bisque firing, glazing, then a hotter glaze firing — and you do not own the result until it survives two trips through a kiln at 1,000 to 1,300°C.¹ The wheel is maybe a tenth of the craft; the firing and glazing are the other nine-tenths, and the frustrating ones.²

It is booming for a reason a tech-forward reader will recognise. An Axios trend piece framed the surge as anti-digital: wellness-driven, tactile, a hands-on

counterweight to knowledge work, and the studios now count corporate-wellness and university demand as named revenue channels.³ The scale is real if fuzzily measured — market trackers put the pottery-ceramics market near US\$12.3 billion in 2025, with the faster-growing studio-"experience" segment around US\$1.2 billion, order-of-magnitude not gospel.³ The community is large too: r/ceramics counts about 164,000 members, r/Pottery is the larger general sub, and the hobby's tentpole personality, potter Florian Gadsby, has 1.8 million YouTube subscribers.⁴ The next two pages descend the rest of the way.⁴

2 fires

A POT MUST SURVIVE — BISQUE, THEN GLAZE, AT UP TO 1,300°C — BEFORE IT IS YOURS. IT IS WHY THE WHEEL IS THE EASY 10% AND THE KILN IS WHERE THE HEARTBREAK LIVES.¹

CENTERING

TWO FIRES

THE KILN QUESTION

THE TRUTH THE WHOLE HOBBY RESTS ON

Here is the thing the romance hides, and every honest potter will tell you: most hobbyists never own a kiln. A real one needs a dedicated 240V circuit, serious amperage, wall clearance and outdoor-ducted venting — which most apartments and condos simply cannot provide.⁵ So for the affluent city dweller the "home studio" fantasy is, in practice, a membership hobby: you throw at home or in a studio, but you rent the fire. Hold that through the gear pages — the wheel is the cheap part; the kiln is the wall.⁵

WHO FALLS IN — THE COUNTERWEIGHT SEEKERS

The convert is usually a mid-career professional chasing a hands-on antidote to a screen-bound job, arriving through a one-off "trial" class and staying for the tactility.³ The pull is its difficulty: unlike a feed, clay gives nothing back for free, and the wheel demands your whole body — the opposite of doom-scrolling, which is why the burnt-out love it.³

THE REALITY CHECK — THE WHEEL IS NOT THE POT

The gateway is also the trap. Centering feels like the craft, but the craft is really glazing and firing — the parts with no wheel to romanticise and every chance to fail.² You will make dozens of wonky mugs, and an S-crack can split a piece you loved on the final fire from a mistake made on day one.²

SOURCES 1 Craft & gateway — wheel-throwing vs hand-building; the pipeline (wet → leather-hard trim → bone-dry greenware → bisque → glaze firing) at ~1,000–1,300°C; "centering" the gateway moment — r/Pottery; getpotteryclass; Pottery Crafters, summarised. 2 Wheel is ~10% of the craft, firing/glazing the rest; S-cracks from poor base compression — r/Pottery; Ceramic Arts Daily, 2026 (attributed). 3 The boom — Axios ("Why pottery is building in popularity," 7 Aug 2025): anti-digital, wellness-driven; corporate-wellness/university demand a named channel; market ~US\$12.3B (2025), studio-experience ~US\$1.24B — Axios; dataintel; SNS Insider / Grand View aggregates (research estimates vary — DIRECTIONAL, flagged). 4 Communities — r/ceramics ~164k (GummySearch); r/Pottery the larger sub (Reddit hid counts Sept 2025 — exact held); Florian Gadsby 1.8M (Wikipedia). 5 Kiln reality — a home electric kiln needs a dedicated 240V circuit, amperage, clearance and outdoor-ducted venting; most condo dwellers cannot fire at home → a membership hobby — Ceramic Arts Daily; Skutt kiln-room guide, 2026.

THE DEEP END · THE COMMUNITY & THE GEAR

Where They Gather, and the Wheel Worth Buying Once

The front door is a subreddit; the deep water is a forum arguing about firing atmospheres it will never agree on. And the gear, read buy-once, skips the stalling tabletop wheels entirely — the real entry is the quietest direct-drive wheel on the market, and a kiln decision you make with an electrician, not a shopping cart.

The community splits along the craft's own fault line. Reddit is the town square: r/Pottery, the larger, beginner-friendly sub, is wall-to-wall wheel-buying advice and "what went wrong" firing photos; r/ceramics (~164k) skews sculptural — and the gap between the two subs is the functional-versus-sculptural argument in miniature.¹ The authority voice is Ceramic Arts Network and *Ceramics Monthly*, whose Ceramic Arts Daily forums host the evergreen fight — electric versus gas versus wood firing (electric for safety and consistency; gas and wood for atmospheric surfaces, at the cost of ventilation and unpredictability).¹ The real front door, though, is YouTube: Florian Gadsby (1.8M) for meditative porcelain; Old Forge Creations, a self-taught designer-turned-potter; Ingleton Pottery for old-school demos.²

Read buy-once, the gear is blunt about where the disposable tier ends — skip the low-torque tabletop wheels, which the r/Pottery consensus says stall the moment you lean on the clay.³ The **wheel** to buy once is the Nidec-Shimpo VL-Whisper (~US\$1,850): a half-horsepower direct-drive brushless motor, no belt, no vibration, 100lb centering, a five-year warranty, and a reputation as "the quietest wheel on the market."³ The studio alternative is a Brent (by Amaco) — belt-driven, "buy it once, hand it to your grandkid," Model B (150lb) to CXC (300lb).³ The **kiln** is the real money and the real gate: a Skutt KM-818 (~US\$2,500) is the starter, the KM-1027 (~US\$3,995, 7 cu ft) the popular full-size, an L&L e23T (~US\$2,500–2,900) the durable rival — all needing 240V and, indoors, a downdraft vent ducted outside.⁴

THE CHATTER — "THE QUIETEST WHEEL," AND THE FIGHT OVER FIRE

Two verdicts recur, attributed to the boards. On wheels the agreement is unusual: the Shimpo VL-Whisper is so consistently the quiet buy-once default that the phrase follows it everywhere, with Brents the "louder but eternal" counter.³ On firing there is no consensus by design — electric wins on safety, gas and wood on surfaces you can't get otherwise — and the correction underneath is that the room's *venting*, not the kiln's badge, is what beginners get dangerously wrong.⁴

THE BUY-ONCE STACK

PIECE	REAL PRICE
Shimpo VL-Whisper wheel	~\$1,850
Brent Model B wheel	~\$1,400+
Skutt KM-818 kiln	~\$2,500
Skutt KM-1027 kiln	~\$3,995
L&L e23T kiln	~\$2,500–2,900
Downdraft vent	~\$300–500
Mudtools rib / DiamondCore set	~\$9 / ~\$119

USD, retailer listings Aug 2026 (Blick / The Ceramic Shop / Soolla); Brent dollar figure held/range.⁴

\$5–8k+

A FULL HOME STUDIO, BUY-ONCE: WHEEL + KILN + VENTING + THE 240V ELECTRICAL WORK + TOOLS + SHELVING — BEFORE THE FIRST MUG, AND BEFORE YOU'VE PRICED WHETHER YOUR HOME CAN EVEN TAKE THE CIRCUIT.⁴

WHERE ENTHUSIASTS BUY

Wheels and kilns from Dick Blick, The Ceramic Shop, Sheffield and Clay-King, or Amaco/Skutt/L&L direct; fine tools from Soolla. The connoisseur's ribs are Mudtools polymer (~\$9 each); the trimming upgrade a DiamondCore carbide set. The buy-once move: rent the kiln at a studio until you've fired ~20 pieces, then buy the wheel first and treat the kiln as a separate, electrician-gated decision.⁵

SOURCES 1 Community — r/Pottery (larger general sub), r/ceramics (~164k, GummySearch; more sculptural); Ceramic Arts Network / *Ceramics Monthly* + Ceramic Arts Daily forums (electric-vs-gas-vs-wood firing; venting) — GummySearch; Ceramic Arts Daily, 2026 (forum threads via search — flagged). 2 Personalities — Florian Gadsby (1.8M, Wikipedia); Old Forge Creations; Ingleton Pottery; Tim See, Earth Nation Ceramics — The Ceramic School; Wikipedia. 3 Wheels — skip low-torque tabletop (r/Pottery; they stall); Nidec-Shimpo VL-Whisper ~US\$1,850 (½HP direct-drive, 100lb, 5-yr, "quietest wheel"); Brent (Amaco) Model B 150lb / CXC 300lb (2026 price held) — The Studio Manager; Shimpo; Amaco. 4 Kilns — Skutt KM-818 ~US\$2,499–2,791; KM-1027 ~US\$3,995 (7 cu ft, Cone 10); L&L e23T ~US\$2,495–2,885; all 240V, indoors a downdraft vent ducted outdoors; full home studio ~US\$5,000–8,000+ incl. electrical — Dick Blick; The Ceramic Shop; Skutt guide, 2026 (retailer ranges — flagged). 5 Retailers/tools — Dick Blick, The Ceramic Shop, Sheffield, Clay-King, Soolla, maker-direct; Mudtools ribs ~\$9, DiamondCore set ~\$119; rent the kiln first — Soolla; r/Pottery, 2026.

THE DEEP END · THE CULTURE & THE FIRST NINETY DAYS

The Smart Kiln, the S-Crack, and the Studio You Should Rent First

The cutting edge this year is a controller that fires your kiln from your phone; the enduring reality is a craft where the money pit is the fire, not the wheel. Here is the vocabulary, the honest starter path, the Singapore studios worth a trial class — and the sceptic's case for why most of you should never buy a kiln at all.

The genuine step-change of the past year is the smart kiln controller. SDS Industries' TAP II Pro (August 2025) put a WiFi touchscreen on a multi-zone controller with a "Cone-Fire" mode that bakes the pyrometric-cone chart into the firmware — the firing schedule leaving the mechanical Kiln Sitter era for a phone.¹ The verdict is honest: promising, but too new to judge — real momentum, not a proven upgrade.¹ The schools stay fixed — the Leach-Hamada tradition of quiet, functional tableware against high-speed production throwing — and the four beginner mistakes are eternal: clay too wet, arms unbraced, bases uncompressed (hello, S-crack), and drying too fast.²

The rituals are the reward: a kiln opening is a communal lottery, and wood-firings are multi-day, shift-based stoking marathons.² The honest first ninety days invert the shopping instinct: lurk first (watch Florian Gadsby end to end so you grasp the whole pipeline), take a real class, and buy nothing in month one but a personal tool kit — a Mudtools rib, wire and needle tools, a Do-All trimmer, under US\$80.³ Convert to a membership at week six; only then consider a home wheel, treating the kiln as a separate, electrician-gated decision.³

THE SCEPTIC — THE WHEEL IS THE CHEAP PART; THE KILN IS THE WALL

The home-studio dream is, for most, a fantasy the electricians kill. A real kiln needs 240V, amperage, clearance and outdoor-ducted venting — so most condo dwellers cannot fire at home, which makes this a membership hobby.⁴ The money pit is the kiln, the electrical and the glaze materials, not the wheel; the "experience market" booms partly because churn is high — plenty pay for a month, make three wonky mugs, and drift. And the S-crack breaks hearts: it survives bisque, then splits on the glaze fire from a compression error made on day one.⁴

THE GLOSSARY — SAY IT LIKE A POTTER

Greenware unfired · **leather-hard** firm enough to trim · **bisque** first firing · **wedging** kneading air out · **centering** the make-or-break move · **trimming** carving the foot · **grog** grit for strength · **reduction** vs **oxidation** (gas/wood vs electric) · **S-crack** the base split · **cone** the heat-work marker.²

SINGAPORE — A TRIAL BEFORE A WHEEL

STUDIO	REAL PRICE
Mud Rock — 5-lesson course	S\$315
Mud Rock — trial throw	S\$83
Thow Kwang — 3-hr workshop	S\$80

SGD, Sassy Mama SG, 2026; Goodman from ~S\$190; WeekendWorker & Urth & Phire run memberships.⁵

NEXT DESCENTS — THE READER PICKS TOMORROW'S HOBBY

Watchmaking — the same buy-once, grow-into-your-tools craft, at 1:1 scale under a loupe.

Home espresso — the grinder is the new kiln: a daily ritual with a bottomless upgrade ladder.

Mechanical keyboards — custom builds, group buys and the endless hunt for the perfect "thock."

SOURCES 1 Cutting edge — SDS Industries TAP II Pro multi-zone kiln controller (Aug 2025): WiFi touchscreen, up to 3 zones, Cone-Fire mode; community verdict "too new to judge" — PRWeb; kilncontrol.com (hype-vs-impact open — flagged); studio-membership boom the bigger new force — Axios, Aug 2025. 2 Culture — jargon glossary (standard terms); Leach-Hamada vs production throwing; four beginner mistakes (clay too wet, unbraced arms, uncompressed base → S-crack, too-fast drying); rituals (kiln openings, Empty Bowls, wood-firings) — getpotteryclass; Pottery Crafters; r/Pottery, 2026. 3 First 90 days — lurk, take a class, buy only a personal tool kit (Mudtools rib ~\$9, Do-All trimmer ~\$26, under US\$80), convert to a membership at week 6, kiln a later electrician-gated decision — Soolla; Clay-King; r/Pottery, 2026. 4 Sceptic — kiln needs 240V/amperage/clearance/outdoor venting (most condos can't fire → membership hobby); money pit is kiln + electrical + glaze; churn high; S-crack heartbreak — Ceramic Arts Daily; Skutt kiln-room guide, 2026. 5 Singapore — Mud Rock (5-lesson S\$315, trial S\$83); Thow Kwang (dragon kiln; 3-hr S\$80/S\$65 child; excursion S\$74); Goodman Ceramic (from ~S\$190); WeekendWorker & Urth & Phire (memberships) — Sassy Mama SG; weekendworker.sg; uppottery.com.sg (some SG figures verify on site — flagged).

FITNESS · THE SMALLEST DOSE

Five Minutes a Week, and the "No Time" Excuse Is Officially Dead

A new pooled analysis of "exercise snacks" — bouts of five minutes or less, done a couple of times a day — found they measurably raised $VO_2\text{max}$, at total volumes as low as about four and a half minutes a week. Since $VO_2\text{max}$ is one of the strongest predictors of how long you live, that is a real longevity lever hiding in the stairwell. The catch: it helped the previously inactive most, and the number your watch reports is not the number the lab measures. General guidance, not medical advice.

The most useful fitness finding of the fortnight fits in a stairwell. A 2026 meta-analysis in the British Journal of Sports Medicine pooled eleven randomised trials and 414 inactive adults and found that "exercise snacks" — brief bouts of five minutes or less, done at least twice a day on three or more days a week — significantly raised $VO_2\text{max}$, by roughly 5 to 17% with two or more snacks a day, at total training volumes as low as about four and a half minutes a week.¹ Why a mid-40s reader should care is the outcome, not the effort: $VO_2\text{max}$ is among the strongest predictors of longevity there is — moving from the bottom fitness quartile to merely below-average is associated with roughly half the all-cause mortality.² A snack is a stair sprint, a thirty-second bodyweight circuit, a hard walk up the carpark ramp. No gym, no kit, and the "no time" excuse retired with the study.¹

The continuity number stays where last issue left it, restated honestly. A Harvard/BJSM analysis of

~147,000 adults over ~thirty years found 90 to 120 minutes a week of strength training associated with 13% lower all-cause, 19% cardiovascular and 27% neurological mortality — plateauing near 120 minutes, up to ~45% paired with aerobic work.³ One caveat: the version that recirculated on 8 August is the same June study, not new data.³ Together, the mid-40s prescription is cheap: two hours of strength a week to a ceiling, plus $VO_2\text{max}$ snacks in the cracks of the day. Not medical advice.²

~4.5 min

A WEEK — THE TOTAL "SNACKED" HARD EFFORT THAT MEASURABLY LIFTED $VO_2\text{MAX}$ IN THESE TRIALS. THE BENEFIT IS LARGEST FOR THE PREVIOUSLY INACTIVE; IF YOU ALREADY TRAIN, TREAT IT AS A SUPPLEMENT, NOT A SHORTCUT.¹

EXERCISE SNACKS

$VO_2\text{MAX}$ IS THE LEVER

NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

THE CHATTER — THE LONGEVITY CROWD REDISCOVERS CARDIO

The wellness discourse has quietly pivoted from steps to $VO_2\text{max}$. A 2026 Life Time survey found strength training tops people's stated priorities and 82% say they are "focused more on wellbeing."⁴ On r/longevity and in Peter Attia's audience the running argument is which target to chase — a $VO_2\text{max}$ percentile or a strength benchmark — and the "exercise snacks" data lands as a gift to the time-poor end of it: a way to move the longevity dial that needs no training block, only a willingness to take the stairs at pace.⁴

THE SCEPTIC — YOUR WATCH IS NOT A METABOLIC CART

Hold the $VO_2\text{max}$ enthusiasm to what's measurable. Wearable estimates run ~7 $\text{ml}\cdot\text{kg}^{-1}\cdot\text{min}^{-1}$ off lab values, so the number your ring shows is a trend line, not a truth.⁵ A large share of an elite $VO_2\text{max}$ is genetic, so a training gain doesn't guarantee the lifespan payoff the epidemiology implies — and the snack trials helped the previously inactive most, so a reader who already trains should expect diminishing returns.⁵ Useful, cheap, real — but not magic; clear hard efforts with a doctor if sedentary. Not medical advice.¹

SOURCES 1 "Exercise snacks" meta-analysis — Rodríguez, Quintana-Cepedal, Cheval et al., British Journal of Sports Medicine 2026 (60:133–143); 11 RCTs, 414 inactive/older adults; bouts ≤ 5 min, $\geq 2\times/\text{day}$ raised $VO_2\text{max}$ (+5–17% with 2+/day) at volumes as low as ~4.5 min/week — BJSM; Men's Journal; Examine. 2 $VO_2\text{max}$ –longevity — among the strongest predictors; bottom-quartile $\rightarrow$ below-average $\approx$ ~50% lower all-cause mortality — Peter Attia MD; UK Biobank. Observational. 3 Harvard/BJSM strength analysis — ~147,000 adults, ~30 yr; 90–119 min/week $\approx$ 13% lower all-cause / 19% CVD / 27% neurological mortality, plateau ~120 min; the 8 Aug item is the same June study recirculating — Harvard Health; Washington Post (16 Jun 2026). 4 Longevity discourse — 2026 Life Time survey (strength tops priorities, 82% "focused more on wellbeing") — Barchart/Life Time. 5 Sceptic — wearable $VO_2\text{max}$ ~7 $\text{ml}\cdot\text{kg}^{-1}\cdot\text{min}^{-1}$ off lab; large genetic component; snacks helped the inactive most — WKU validation; Critical MAS, 2026. Not medical advice.

THE DIARY · THE DATED AGENDA

One Ticket to Set an Alarm for This Week, Then an October Crunch

BIGBANG's general sale drops on Thursday — the single act-now item in a Kallang autumn that stacks Post Malone, the Weeknd and Singapore's first-ever F1 Sprint into six weeks. In Japan, September and November carry the sumo and the art, and the family-proof evergreens run all year. Lock the flights and the rooms before the diaries fill.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

- 17 OCT** ★ **BIGBANG — 〈XX: COSMOS〉**
NATIONAL STADIUM · 1 NIGHT, RETURN AFTER 11 YRS · GENERAL SALE 13 AUG 10AM
- 25 SEP** ★ **Post Malone — Big Ass World Tour**
NATIONAL STADIUM · ON SALE, TICKETMASTER SG
- 2–3 Oct** ★ **The Weeknd — After Hours Til Dawn**
NATIONAL STADIUM · 2 NIGHTS, HIS BIGGEST SG SHOWS · REGISTRATION PRESALE
- 9–11 Oct** ★ **F1 Singapore GP — first-ever Sprint**
MARINA BAY · SAT SPRINT, SEASON FINALE ROUND · ZONE 4 WALKABOUT
- 3 OCT** **ITZY**
SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · CLASHES WITH THE WEEKND/F1 WEEKEND
- 17–22 Dec** ★ **BTS — 'ARIRANG' (4 nights)**
NATIONAL STADIUM · REPORTED SOLD OUT · VERIFIED RESALE ONLY

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH TRAVELLING FOR

- 13–27 Sep** ★ **Grand Sumo — Aki Basho**
RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · 15-DAY TOURNAMENT · BUY EARLY
- all year** **teamLab Borderless**
AZABUDAI HILLS, TOKYO · TIMED ENTRY · THE LOW-FRICTION 11-YO WIN
- 3 OCT** **Tamagawa Fireworks Festival**
FUTAKO-TAMAGAWA, SETAGAYA · LARGE AUTUMN HANABI
- 10–11 Oct** **Fukuro / Tokyo Yosakoi Matsuri**
IKEBUKURO · FREE CITY DANCE FESTIVAL · KID-FRIENDLY
- 4–8 Nov** ★ **Art Week Tokyo**
MORI ART MUSEUM + CITY GALLERIES · ROPPONGI HUB

PLANNING NOTES — SET THE ALARM FOR THURSDAY, THEN BRACE FOR OCTOBER

The one to act on now: BIGBANG's return to the National Stadium (17 Oct, one night) had its VIP presale on 11 August, with the general sale on Thursday 13 August at 10am via Ticketmaster SG, S\$158–498 — a historically fast Kallang sell-out, so the mid-tiers will go.¹ Then brace: the Sports Hub stacks Post Malone (25 Sep), the Weeknd (2–3 Oct), the F1 Sprint weekend (9–11 Oct) and BIGBANG (17 Oct) inside four weeks — lock F1-weekend hotels now, because rates and ride-hail surge across Kallang. In Japan, the Aki Basho and Art Week Tokyo are the marquee picks; buy sumo early and time-book teamLab.²

FOR THE FAMILY

With an eleven-year-old, the low-friction wins are the timed and the evergreen: teamLab Borderless at Azabudai (advance slots), the free Yosakoi/Fukuro dance festival, the Tamagawa fireworks, and Christmas Wonderland come year-end. The F1 works for older kids with ear protection and a Zone 4 walkabout; the stadium headliners do not.¹

THE SCEPTIC — A DATE IS NOT A TICKET

"On sale" is not "available": BTS is reported sold out and the Weeknd runs registration-based, so resale means verified platforms, not a stranger's screenshot.¹ And several single-listed dates — ITZY, the F1 Sprint being the season finale — are flagged to reconfirm on official ticketing and formula1.com; a date we can't second-source is one we mark, not bank.²

SOURCES 1 Singapore — BIGBANG (XX: COSMOS) World Tour, National Stadium, 17 Oct 2026 (return after 11 years; VIP presale 11 Aug, Trip.com presale 12 Aug, general sale 13 Aug 10am, Ticketmaster SG, S\$158–498) — MustShareNews; Ticketmaster SG. Post Malone "Big Ass World Tour," National Stadium 25 Sep (Live Nation/Ticketmaster SG). The Weeknd, After Hours Til Dawn, National Stadium 2–3 Oct (registration presale; his biggest SG shows). ITZY, Singapore Indoor Stadium 3 Oct (reconfirm). F1 Singapore GP 9–11 Oct 2026 — 2026 introduces Singapore's first-ever Sprint (Sat), billed as the season's final Sprint round (per listings/RacingNews365 — verify formula1.com). Guns N' Roses, National Stadium 25 Nov (single-listed — reconfirm). BTS 'ARIRANG' 17–22 Dec (4 nights), reported sold out — Live Nation SG (verify). 2 Japan & region — Grand Sumo Aki Basho, Ryōgoku Kokugikan, 13–27 Sep; teamLab Borderless, Azabudai Hills (timed entry); Tamagawa Fireworks 3 Oct (Futako-Tamagawa); Fukuro/Tokyo Yosakoi Matsuri, Ikebukuro 10–11 Oct; Art Week Tokyo 4–8 Nov (Mori Art Museum + galleries); Grand Sumo Kyushu Basho, Fukuoka, 8–22 Nov — Ryōgoku Kokugikan; Art Week Tokyo; Tokyo Cheapo; Japan Cheapo. Single-listed dates flagged to reconfirm.

THE TABLE • SINGAPORE'S NEWEST OPENINGS

A Michelin Chef's "Accessible" Bet, Jeju Pork Over Charcoal, and a Value Teishoku

The new arrivals span a one-star chef's second, cheaper room on Neil Road, Singapore's first Jeju-pork tonkatsu specialist in the CBD, and — opening mid-month — a Japanese grilled-fish chain landing its first overseas branch in a heartland mall. One is already winning the reviews; two are still too raw to judge.

Start with the one the critics have already warmed to. Assaggi, which opened on 10 August at 77A Neil Road, is the second restaurant from Denis Lucchi, chef of one-Michelin-star Buona Terra — his cooking, as the room's own pitch has it, "at a fraction of Buona Terra's price."¹ The format is set-menu only and deliberately "imperfect": a three-course lunch at S\$58++, and two dinner tasting menus — a Signature Journey and a pasta-forward Pasta Journey — at S\$88++ each.¹ Early press ran uniformly positive: Time Out and FACT frame it as a smart Michelin-chef accessibility play, and middleclass.sg singled out a showstopper whipped Occelli-butter brioche and flagged it, usefully for a family dinner, as a rare strong *non-drinker's* fine-diner. No dissent has surfaced yet — but "no dissent" at a fortnight old means early, not proven.¹

The CBD's new obsession is a cutlet. Katsu by Kyu, in OUE Downtown Gallery on Shenton Way, bills itself as Singapore's first tonkatsu specialist using Jeju pork exclusively — ten-day dry-aged cutlets finished over rice-straw charcoal, with *gamasot* rice in cast-iron pots, in a 44-seat hanok-style room.² Cuts run S\$30–38++. The pickup across HungryGoWhere, DanielFoodDiary and Eatbook is fast and warm on ingredient quality and the charcoal theatre — with a consistent caveat that the bill climbs once premium sets and curry stack, and that a lunchtime office queue has formed.² Go off-peak to beat the CBD crush.²

Two more round out the fortnight, both value-tilted. Charcoal Grill Shinpachi — the first overseas outpost of a beloved Japanese charcoal-grilled-fish *teishoku* chain (100-plus branches at home) — opens 15 August

at NEX, grilled-fish sets from S\$8.90 with rice, pickles and miso soup.³ Too new to call on taste, but the pre-open coverage is hooked on the price-to-authenticity ratio — the value-and-family pick for a Japan-obsessed household. And Mimmo Bakery, a French-Italian patisserie with Hong-Kong-inspired flavours, has joined the CBD wave at Asia Square — too new for reviews, flagged for a follow.⁴

THE BUZZ — WHAT THE FOOD MEDIA ACTUALLY SAY

Summarised in our own words: the loudest early love is for Katsu by Kyu (the dry-aged Jeju cutlet and the charcoal finish, tempered by "gets pricey" and "already a queue"), while Assaggi is the critics' quiet win — the accessible-Michelin angle and the non-drinker's tasting menu drawing warm, near-unanimous first press.¹ Shinpachi is pure anticipation on the value-and-authenticity pitch until it opens on the 15th; Mimmo is a name to watch, not yet a verdict.³ The booking advice: reserve Assaggi's small room ahead, hit Katsu off-peak, and walk into Shinpachi in its first fortnight expecting a wait.²

THE HONESTY LEDGER — ONE WARMLY REVIEWED, THREE TOO NEW

Only Assaggi carries anything like a settled early read, and even that is a fortnight of warm press, not a track record.¹ Katsu by Kyu is days old and riding a launch queue; Shinpachi has not opened; Mimmo is unreviewed — all three are "too new to call," said plainly rather than dressed as praise.³ We rotate venues each issue (last issue's 1887, Loulouca, POP Bakery and LINKUS are held, not re-listed) and print nothing we can't stand behind.⁴

ASSAGGI • THE CRITICS' WIN

KATSU • JEJU CHARCOAL

SHINPACHI • TOO NEW

SOURCES 1 Assaggi — 77A Neil Road, opened 10 Aug 2026; second restaurant from Denis Lucchi (one-Michelin-star Buona Terra), set-menu-only "imperfect by choice"; 3-course lunch S\$58++, dinner tasting menus (Signature / Pasta Journey) S\$88++, supplements S\$18; cocktails via Bar Kakure; highlights pappardelle w/ ossobuco & saffron, tableside Amatriciana, whipped Occelli-butter brioche; flagged a strong non-drinker's fine-diner; uniformly positive early press, no dissent yet (early) — Time Out SG; FACT Magazine; middleclass.sg, Aug 2026. 2 Katsu by Kyu — OUE Downtown Gallery, Shenton Way; Singapore's first tonkatsu specialist using Jeju pork exclusively, 10-day dry-aged, rice-straw charcoal finish, gamasot rice, 44-seat hanok room; tenderloin S\$30++, loin S\$32++, premium loin S\$38++ (curry +S\$6); praise for quality/theatre, caveat on price stacking + lunch queue — HungryGoWhere; DanielFoodDiary; The Ranting Panda; Eatbook, Aug 2026. 3 Charcoal Grill Shinpachi (Shinpachi Shokudo) — NEX #B1-80A, Serangoon, opens 15 Aug 2026; first overseas branch of the Japanese charcoal-grilled-fish teishoku chain (100+ outlets); 10+ sets from S\$8.90; too new to call on taste — Eatbook; Sassy Mama; TheSmartLocal, Aug 2026. 4 Mimmo Bakery — Asia Square Tower 1, Shenton Way; French/Italian pastry with HK-inspired flavours, new to the CBD Aug wave; too new to call — early listings, 2026. Prior venues (1887 by André, Loulouca, POP Bakery, LINKUS) held from No. 69, not re-reviewed.

THE LONG READ · THE UNDERCURRENT

The Man the AI Boom Laid Off Built Korea a Map for the Broke

In March a laid-off Korean developer capped his own food budget at ₩10,000 a day and built a crowdsourced map of every meal cheaper than that. Within a month it had 1.3 million visitors. It is the totem of "jjantech" — thrift reframed as a competitive skill — and the first consumer subculture visibly shaped by white-collar AI displacement. When the FT calls it "Korea's jjantech underclass," it will already have a name, a scoreboard and 2,500 restaurants on it.

The origin story is almost too neat to be true, and it is true. In March 2026 Choi Sung-soo, a 34-year-old software developer who had lost his job in an AI-related restructuring, was living on his severance and had capped his own daily food budget at ₩10,000 — about US\$7.¹ So he built a tool for everyone else doing the same: *Geoji Map* — the "Beggar Map" — a crowdsourced web map of restaurants and cafés serving a meal under ₩10,000.¹ It drew 1.3 million visitors within a month of launch and now lists more than 2,500 places nationwide, running, in the creator's own dry phrase, on "the collective intelligence and strict evaluation of beggars."¹ The tool for surviving the AI layoffs was itself born from one — and that recursion is the whole story in miniature.¹

The map is the totem of something larger the Koreans have already named. *Jjantech* — a portmanteau of *jjanhada* ("stingy") and "tech" — recasts extreme frugality as a strategy, a skill, a scoreboard, and Korean commentators frame it explicitly as the successor to the 2010s YOLO spending ethos.² Its sister platforms are *geojibang*, "rooms for beggars" — group chats whose members openly police and shame one another's spending.² The backdrop is a squeeze with a specific shape: youth unemployment hit 7.4% in the first quarter of 2026, the highest since 2021, even as consumer inflation ran at 2.2% — a generation concluding, out loud, that the YOLO deal was never on offer for them.³ The next two pages follow the money, the mood, and what it means.³

A generation that decided the YOLO deal was never on offer has turned going without into a game you can win — and built the apps to keep score.

1.3M

VISITORS TO THE BEGGAR MAP WITHIN A MONTH OF ITS MARCH 2026 LAUNCH — A CROWDSOURCED MAP OF 2,500+ MEALS UNDER ₩10,000, BUILT BY A DEVELOPER THE AI BOOM HAD JUST MADE REDUNDANT.¹

What makes it an undercurrent is not the thrift — recessions always breed thrift — but the register. Where an older cohort hid its scrimping, this one wears "beggar" (거지) as an ironic badge, turning penny-pinching into a shared, gamified identity with bragging rights: the map rewards whoever verifies the cheapest good meal; the group chats reward whoever spends least.² That inversion — shame drained out of scarcity and replaced by a leaderboard — is what lets it spread as culture rather than coping.²

THE BUILDER — THE TOOL FOR THE LAID-OFF, BUILT BY THE LAID-OFF

Choi Sung-soo is the figure the story turns on. A developer made redundant in an AI restructuring, living on severance, he set himself a ₩10,000 daily food cap and then, rather than merely economise, built the infrastructure for others to do it — a public map that a million people used within weeks.¹ He describes it, half-joking, as running on the "collective intelligence and strict evaluation of beggars." The self-mockery is the point: it is how a generation makes agency out of a squeeze it did not choose.¹

SOURCES 1 *Geoji Map* (거지맵, "Beggar Map") — launched ~20 Mar 2026, crowdsourced map of meals under ₩10,000 (~US\$7); ~1.3 million visitors within a month; 2,500+ venues nationwide; creator Choi Sung-soo, 34, a developer who lost his job in an AI-related restructuring and capped his own daily food budget at ₩10,000; runs on "the collective intelligence and strict evaluation of beggars" — SCMP; Korea Times; Seoul Economic Daily; VnExpress, 2026 (cross-outlet synthesis, figures to spot-check — flagged). 2 "Jjantech" (짠테크, stingy + tech) — frugality as skill/strategy, successor to YOLO; "geojibang" (거지방) chats policing spending; "beggar" (거지) an ironic badge — Seoul Economic Daily (19 May 2026); Korea Times (20 Apr 2026). 3 Backdrop — youth unemployment 7.4% Q1 2026 (highest since 2021); inflation +2.2% y/y (Mar 2026) — SCMP citing official data (Statistics Korea primary not retrieved — flagged). Sentiment attributed as reported.

Follow the money and jjantech stops being a meme and becomes a retail shift. The clearest tell is Daiso, the everything-under-₩5,000 chain: its clothing sales jumped roughly 180% year on year in January 2026 and about 140% in February, ₩5,000 windbreakers sold out, and its clothing range ballooned from around 270 items at the end of 2023 to some 700 by the end of 2025 — a discount store becoming a fashion destination by default.¹ Convenience stores are the other proof: CU, in a March 2026 renewal, cut its triangle *gimbap* to ₩1,100 and rice bowls to ₩3,300, positioning the *konbini* as the no-spend generation's default kitchen.¹ When the cheapest tier of retail is the fastest-growing, the consumer has voted with an empty wallet.¹

Underneath the retail sits a split that jjantech both expresses and disguises. Korea's economy is running a K-shaped divide: the semiconductor-and-AI boom lifts asset-holders at the top while "survival spending" spreads at the bottom, where the lowest income quintile spent 42.5% of its outlays on just housing-and-utilities (21.7%) and food (20.8%) in the first quarter of 2026.² That is the cruel symmetry the Beggar Map draws in one screen: the same boom that headlines the country's GDP and enriches the chip winners is hollowing the entry-level jobs beneath it — and the people it strands are gamifying the shortfall rather than absorbing it quietly.²

When the cheapest tier of retail is the fastest-growing — Daiso clothing up 180% in a month — the consumer has voted with an empty wallet.

The right historical analogy is not a Western recession but a Japanese one — with the emotional sign flipped. After Japan's bubble burst, a cohort of the young simply stopped wanting: no cars, no luxury, minimal consumption, what Kenichi Ohmae called the "low-desire society" and the media the *satori sedai*, the "enlightened generation" that had given up.³ Korea's jjantech is that diagnosis rewritten for the platform age: same root cause — a young cohort priced out of the growth story — but where Japan's satori kids went quiet and resigned, Korea's beggars are loud, ironic and organised, building apps and leaderboards for their austerity.³ The difference is the tell. A resigned generation withdraws; a gamified one competes, and a competition needs an audience, a platform, and a scoreboard — all of which jjantech has.³ It is also why the movement produces *data* rather than mere anecdote: a resigned cohort leaves no trace, but a competitive one leaves a map with 2,500 pins, group chats with rankings, and a Daiso sales chart that reads like a scoreboard of its own.¹

The discount store as fashion

Daiso Korea clothing sales, y/y change



Clothing SKUs: ~270 (end-2023) to ~700 (end-2025). ₩5,000 windbreakers sold out.

Source: Seoul Economic Daily, 25–26 Mar 2026.

A Meridian chart from Korean-press figures — directional, cross-outlet.

THE VOICE — DEFIANT, NOT DEFEATED

The mood the coverage keeps catching is not despair but defiant self-mockery. Participants wear "beggar" as an ironic badge; the *geojibang* chats openly shame overspenders, and the Beggar Map turns finding the cheapest verified meal into a small win with bragging rights.² Frugality has shifted from a private embarrassment to a shared, gamified identity — a generation that concluded the YOLO deal was never on offer, and decided to make a sport of going without.²

SOURCES 1 Retail proof — Daiso Korea (everything under ₩5,000): clothing sales ~+180% y/y Jan 2026, ~+140% Feb 2026; ₩5,000 windbreakers sold out; clothing SKUs ~270 (end-2023) → ~700 (end-2025); CU convenience stores cut triangle *gimbap* to ₩1,100 and rice bowls to ₩3,300 in a Mar 2026 renewal ("no-spend generation's default kitchen") — Seoul Economic Daily (25–26 Mar 2026); convenience-store trade coverage, 2026 (Korean-press figures, cross-outlet — flagged). 2 K-shaped split — semiconductor/AI boom lifts asset-holders while "survival spending" spreads; bottom income quintile spent 42.5% of consumption on housing+utilities (21.7%) and food (20.8%) in Q1 2026; sentiment ("beggar" as ironic badge, *geojibang* shaming) — Seoul Economic Daily (19 May & 2 Jun 2026); SCMP; Korea Times, 2026 (summarised, attributed). 3 Analogy — Japan's post-bubble "low-desire society" (Kenichi Ohmae) / *satori sedai* ("enlightened generation"), young cohort withdrawing from consumption; Korea's jjantech as the gamified, social-media-native, defiant sequel — desk analysis on Ohmae's framing + Korean-platform coverage. Local sentiment attributed as reported, never invented.

Read it all together and jjantech is the first consumer subculture visibly shaped by white-collar AI displacement — and that is why it matters far beyond Seoul. The chain is direct: the semiconductor-and-AI boom that headlines Korea's growth and enriches its asset-holders is the same force hollowing out the entry-level and mid-tier jobs beneath it; the man who built the survival tool was laid off by *that boom*, and built it for the people it is stranding.¹ Every previous automation panic worried about factory and clerical work. This one is being lived, and gamified, by the developers and office workers the technology was supposed to empower — and they have responded not with resignation but with a scoreboard.¹ A K-shaped economy is eating its own young, and the young are livestreaming the meal.²

The signal worth carrying past Korea is the corporate tell. Watch what the retailers do: Daiso and CU are already re-engineering their assortments around the "beggar" consumer, and the next stage is brands *marketing* to austerity rather than aspiration — the death of the YOLO consumer who powered Korea's 2010s retail boom.³ That is the shape of the thing coming for every advanced Asian economy with an AI-heavy top and a squeezed middle, Singapore included: when the aspirational consumer stops aspiring, the whole marketing edifice built on wanting-more has to be rebuilt on spending-less.³ When the FT runs this in three weeks, the frame will be "Korea's AI boom has a jjantech underclass." The underclass already has the map, the vocabulary and the leaderboard — and it named itself first.¹

A K-shaped economy is eating its own young — and the young are livestreaming the meal, ₩10,000 at a time.

THE SCEPTIC — IS THRIFT-AS-IDENTITY BEING OVER-READ?

Hold the thesis to account. Frugality booms in every downturn, and "no-spend challenges" are not new — Western outlets ran shallow explainers on Korea's 무지출 챌린지 back in 2022, so a sceptic can fairly ask whether jjantech is a genuine structural shift or a recession reflex dressed in a hashtag.⁴ The hard numbers here — the 1.3-million visitor count, the Daiso surge, the quintile spending split — come from Korean-press reporting synthesised across outlets, not from primary releases this desk could open, and should be spot-checked before they are banked.⁴ What tips it past a reflex is the combination: a named AI-layoff origin, a durable K-shaped divide, corporate assortments already bending to it, and a generation that has built *institutions* — apps, group chats, a shared vocabulary — around the thrift. That is culture, not a mood.⁴

THE READ — FOR A READER WHO WATCHES THE REGION

The lesson is not a stock; it is a direction of travel. The assumption behind every advanced-Asia consumer thesis has been an aspirational young middle class trading up. Jjantech is the loud early signal that in an AI-heavy, K-shaped economy that class can invert — trading *down*, as identity, at scale — and that the winners are the discounters and the convenience chains, not the aspirational brands.³ Watch for the same fault line wherever the AI boom sits atop a squeezed middle: the value retailer, the second-hand platform and the "beggar-map" aggregator may be the growth story, and the premium-consumer thesis the crowded one.³ Singapore, with its own AI-heavy top and cost-of-living squeeze (p5), is not Korea — but the direction of travel is worth watching from here.³

THE THREADS

AI displacement, made visible — the first consumer subculture openly shaped by white-collar automation; the tool for the laid-off, built by the laid-off.¹

Thrift as identity, not shame — a gamified, platform-native austerity with apps, leaderboards and a vocabulary of its own.²

The corporate tell — Daiso and CU already reassorting for the "beggar" consumer; the death of the YOLO shopper is a retail forecast.³

SOURCES 1 The thesis — jjantech as the first consumer subculture visibly shaped by white-collar AI displacement; the Beggar Map's creator laid off in an AI restructuring (see p21) — desk analysis on SCMP; Korea Times; Seoul Economic Daily reporting, 2026. 2 K-shaped divide + gamified thrift as culture (apps, geojibang, vocabulary) — Seoul Economic Daily; SCMP, 2026 (see p22). 3 The corporate tell — Daiso/CU reassorting around the low-budget consumer; "death of the YOLO consumer" — Seoul Economic Daily; convenience-store trade coverage, 2026; desk analysis (a forecast, flagged as such). 4 Sceptic + under-radar check — Western outlets covered the generic "no-spend challenge" (무지출 챌린지) shallowly in 2022 (CNBC Select; Yahoo), but no NYT/BBC/Reuters/FT/Guardian/Economist/Bloomberg FEATURE on the 2026 jjantech / Geoji Map / AI-layoff story exists at filing (coverage: SCMP, Korea Times, Korea Herald, JoongAng, Seoul Economic Daily, VnExpress, Storm Media); hard figures are cross-outlet Korean-press synthesis, primary releases not independently retrieved — flagged, spot-check before banking.

A week of small, steady pressure — a strait that would rather charge rent than reopen, an oil price nudging an inflation print into the light, a household the Rally calls "stretched," an eleven-year-old at the pressure point of the research, and a Korean generation that turned going-without into a scoreboard. Franklin saw it three centuries early: it is the little expenses, the small leak, that sink the great ship. The number that tells us whether the leak widened prints tonight, Singapore time — after we go to press, and honestly held until it does.

— THE DESK, NO. 70

CONSOLIDATED SOURCES

The World — CNN, NPR, NBC News, Al Jazeera, Philadelphia Inquirer, Washington Post, Lloyd's List, TradingEconomics. Singapore — PMO, Mothership, The Star, Malay Mail, Yahoo News SG, SCMP, SingStat, MAS, The Edge, Ethos Books. Property — URA, HDB, The Edge Singapore, 99.co/SRX, Stacked Homes, CBRE, ERA. Technology — Bloomberg, Reuters, TechTimes, Tom's Hardware, Meta AI Research, byteiota, Releasebot, HN, llama.cpp #15396. The Kit — TheNewCamera, Imaging Resource, NotebookCheck, Geeky Gadgets, Gizmochina, TipRanks. The Good Life — Monochrome-Watches, Fratello, WristReview, Watch Advice, Hypebeast, Oracle of Time, louismoinet.com. Screen & Sound — UPI, Consequence, Rolling Stone, NME, Album of the Year/Metacritic, Variety, Screen Daily. Family — The Conversation, MedicalXpress, Techdirt, JAMA Pediatrics, Child Mind Institute, Al Jazeera, Norton/Yahoo, IWF, TED/NPR. Macro — TradingEconomics, stockanalysis.com, Investing.com, Yahoo Finance, Fortune, Finimize, BLS. Rabbit Hole — Axios, GummySearch, Ceramic Arts Daily, Skutt, Dick Blick, The Ceramic Shop, Soolla, Wikipedia, Sassy Mama SG. Fitness — British Journal of Sports Medicine, Men's Journal, Peter Attia MD, Harvard Health, Washington Post, Life Time. Diary — Ticketmaster SG, Live Nation, MustShareNews, Time Out SG, FACT, HungryGoWhere, DanielFoodDiary, Eatbook. The Long Read — SCMP, Korea Times, Seoul Economic Daily, Korea Herald, JoongAng, VnExpress.

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